



Hindustan Times

Master Plan lays ground for skyscrapers in Delhi

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NEW DELHI: Delhi's Master Plan 2047 has laid the groundwork for more skyscrapers in the capital by notifying a regulatory framework for buildings taller than 100 floors, making density and floor area ratio (FAR) norms more flexible for large chunks of the city, and removing height restrictions on several categories of construction.

The MPD-2047 – which envisions a city with a population of 32 million by 2047 and requiring nearly four million additional houses, triple the current power generation capacity and double the current solid waste management capability – was

Housing the Capital

DDA estimates Delhi will need four million new houses to meet the needs of a surging population. Here's how they will be distributed

1.8mn Transit-oriented development	700,000 Redevelopment
1.2mn Land-pooling	400,000 In-situ rehab of JJ clusters
200,000 High-density corridors	

Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu, Union minister ML Khattar and CM Rekha Gupta at the release of the Master Plan. SANJEEV VERMA/HT

notified by the Union housing and urban affairs ministry on Thursday.

"We have relaxed norms in various categories providing more flexibility. Apart from the areas like the Lutyens' Bungalow zone, low density area and areas around the airport, we

Addressing a joint press conference along with Delhi lieutenant governor TS Sandhu and chief minister Rekha Gupta, Khattar said the Metro network will be expanded to 695km by 2047, six new regional rapid transit system corridors will be built, and 180 sq km of the Yamuna floodplains and the Ridge area will be preserved.

The plan moved away from uniformity in urban planning by tagging various areas and building categories separately, and drafting separate policies for them. Key among these was the framework for taller buildings – or more vertical patterns of development to trim the urban sprawl.

For the first time, the document explicitly defined structures of more than 100 floors as "tall buildings" and classifies them as "landmark developments". It envisaged such buildings in areas with adequate infrastructure, particularly along mass-transit corridors

continued on →9

MP'S SON DRIVING ASTON MARTIN KILLS WOMAN, BOOKED

HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh Rajya Sabha MP Lingamamani Ramesh's son was booked for running a woman over while driving his Aston Martin sports car, said police.

Bhaskar Mukhi (26) died after the car driven by Lingamamani Sanjush (23), allegedly at high speed, hit her when she was crossing the road on August 16. The accused has been booked under section 106(1) (causing death by negligence) of BNS. →96

S.I.T. TO RE-EXAMINE POLICE PROBE IN RAM TEMPLE CASE

Rohit Kumar Singh
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LUCKNOW: A Special Investigation Team (SIT) set up by the Supreme Court to probe allegations of irregularities in accounting for donations at the Ram Temple is likely to re-examine the criminal investigation conducted by the Ayodhya Police, which resulted in the arrest of eight people, police officials said on Thursday. →96

CONSIDER REPRIEVE ON 3-LANGUAGE RULE, SC TELLS CBSE

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday asked CBSE to consider giving a one-time reprieve to students currently in Class 6 from the third-language requirement so that they do not face a mandatory board examination in that language when they reach Class 10, while also protecting existing foreign-language combinations during the transition. →95

{ INQUIRY BEGINS }

6-yr-old Vizag boy dies after teacher slaps him for unfinished homework

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HYDERABAD: A six-year-old boy died after allegedly being slapped by his teacher for not completing his homework at a private school in Visakhapatnam on Thursday, police said.

The incident took place at Little Garden School in the One Town area. The boy was studying in upper kindergarten (UKG). A purported CCTV video from the classroom, which surfaced on social media, shows the boy holding a slate and standing in front of the teacher. He appears to be crying and pleading with her not to beat him. The teacher is seen adjusting his uniform before slapping him on the cheek. Within seconds, the boy collapses onto the teacher. HT

Lko man kills wife at work, shoots sister, himself dead

Aakash Ghosh and Zuheeb Alam Khan
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LUCKNOW: A 37-year-old bank employee allegedly shot dead his estranged 33-year-old wife, also a banker, outside her office in Lucknow on Thursday and later killed his sister before shooting himself dead, police said.

The man, identified as Manas Bajpayee, an assistant manager at a regional business office of the State Bank of India, assaulted and shot dead his wife, Divya Mishra, at around 12.05pm outside the ICICI Bank Gomti Nagar branch after asking her to step out of her car. Bajpayee then fled the spot. "The woman's co-workers at the bank identified the attacker as her husband," said DCP (east) Deeksha Sharma.

Around 12.30pm, Bajpayee reached his home in Husadiya,



An ambulance outside the man's residence.

DEEPAK GUPTA/HT

about 2km from the bank. Police said Bajpayee then uploaded a WhatsApp status in which he purportedly confessed to killing his wife, saying she had "betrayed" him. He wrote that he intended to kill himself and his sister. Police said Bajpayee was subsequently traced to Husadiya

area. The bodies of Bajpayee and his sister were found at his house, police said. "CCTV footage is being checked to piece together the sequence of events. We have sent the bodies for post-mortem examination and further investigation is under way." DCP Sharma said. →96

Sajjan Kumar, convicted for role in '84 riots, dies

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NEW DELHI: Sajjan Kumar, the controversial former Congress member of Parliament who was serving a life term for his role in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, died in a New Delhi Hospital on Thursday. He was 80.

Saidjung Hospital, where he was taken from jail on Thursday morning after exhibiting signs of "altered sensorium", said in a statement that he died at 12.30 pm despite medical and life-support measures being provided. It noted that he had a history of high blood pressure and Parkinson's



Sajjan Kumar

disease and had multiple hospital admissions in the past. Kumar is survived by his wife, two daughters and one son, according to his profile on the Lok Sabha website. The Supreme Court had been scheduled to hear his appeal on Thursday. continued on →9

CHINA SENTENCES PROPERTY GIANT EVERGRANDE'S FOUNDER TO LIFE

BEIJING: China sentenced the founder of embattled property giant Evergrande, Hui Ka Yan, to life in prison and fined the group more than \$2 billion on Thursday for offenses including fraud, five years after a high-profile default. The Shenzhen Intermediate People's Court's decision marks a milestone in Evergrande's saga after it defaulted on more than \$300 billion in liabilities when Chinese authorities cracked down on excessive borrowing in the real estate industry in 2020. →92

INDIA, SINGAPORE EXPAND TIES; INK FOOD SECURITY, TELECOM PACTS

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NEW DELHI: India and Singapore on Thursday concluded agreements for cooperation in telecommunications and food security, and explored ways to enhance collaboration in small modular reactors, semiconductors, space, and cybersecurity at a meeting of a special bilateral ministerial mechanism. "Our discussions explored deeper ties in advanced manufacturing, semiconductors..." said external affairs minister S Jaishankar. →97

intwinbook
New 3-judge apex court bench to hear PMLA review
Farmlands face rainfall deficit despite late spells
Consider plea to curb kids' social media access: HC

A purported CCTV video from the classroom shows the boy standing in a line in front of the teacher. The teacher is seen pulling the boy closer and slapping him on the cheek.

could not independently verify the authenticity of the video.

The school staff rushed him to a hospital where doctors declared him dead on arrival.

The cause of death will be confirmed once the post-mortem examination report is released, hospital officials said.

The Visakhapatnam district education department initiated an inquiry. The boy's parents, alleged that the teacher's assault directly led to the tragedy. →96

NUMBER THEORY

How does the world see India?

By Sreedev Krishnakumar

Seventy-nine years after Independence, India carries far greater economic and geopolitical weight than it once did. But soft power asks a different set of questions. Where is India actually liked? Where does it struggle to leave an impression? Does its claim to speak for the Global South travel beyond diplomatic forums? And does one of the world's largest diaspora communities buy any goodwill? Data from a recently released survey by Pew Research Center offers some clues.

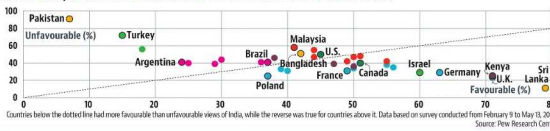


1 India's reputation changes with the map

Pew Research Center's latest 2026 survey finds a median 45% of respondents across 36 countries viewing India favourably, compared with 41% who see it unfavourably. Opinions vary across countries, as expected. Pakistan is the obvious outlier, and hardly a surprising one, with 91% holding an unfavourable opinion of India. But what's more interesting is how sharply the opinion differs elsewhere. Sri Lanka is overwhelmingly

positive at 79%, while Kenya and the UK are at 71% and Europe generally leans favourable. However, in every Latin American country surveyed, unfavourable views of India outweigh favourable ones. Asia is even harder to summarise, ranging from Sri Lanka's warmth to Malaysia's skepticism. To be sure, the takeaway here is not that India is unpopular, but that India's reputation changes dramatically depending on where in the world you ask.

India's global image is far from uniform (Share of respondents with favourable and unfavourable views of India)



2 The Global South paradox

India has always attempted to position itself as a voice of the Global South. However, public opinion does not always follow diplomatic branding. In Pew's 2026 survey, China is viewed more favourably than India in every lower-middle-income country for which survey data is available for both the countries, including Bangladesh, Ghana, Kenya and Nigeria. Even among upper-middle-income countries, China leads in most cases—this includes Indonesia, Malaysia, Thailand.

Turkey, South Africa and every Latin American country surveyed, India's relative advantage shows up much more often in richer countries such as Germany, Sweden, Japan, Israel and the UK. To be sure, there are exceptions as well. Sri Lanka is warmer towards India than China, and the Philippines also gives India an edge. However, the larger pattern is awkward for India as China appears to command broader public favour across much of the Global South we have data for.

China has an edge over India in most middle-income countries

Share of respondents with a favourable view of India and China across countries, by World Bank income group

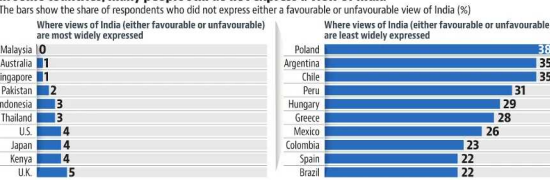


3 India's quieter soft-power challenge

Soft power can fail loudly, when people dislike a country, or more quietly, when they do not express much of an opinion at all. For India, Pakistan, is an obvious example of the first. Almost everyone surveyed in the country had a view of India, and it was overwhelmingly negative. Malaysia, Australia and Singapore also had virtually no respondents without an expressed opinion—only Singapore had more respondents with a favourable opinion of India among them. On the other hand, in Poland, as much as 38% did not offer either a favourable or unfavourable view of India.

The share was 35% in Argentina and Chile, 31% in Peru and more than a fifth in Mexico, Colombia and Brazil. To be sure, the survey data does not tell us whether these respondents know little about India, have yet to form a firm opinion or simply chose not to answer. But the contrast still matters. A country can suffer a reputation deficit when people know what they think and dislike what they see. But India's challenge in parts of Latin America and Europe may also involve something more basic, getting enough people to form a view in the first place.

In some countries, many people still do not express a view of India



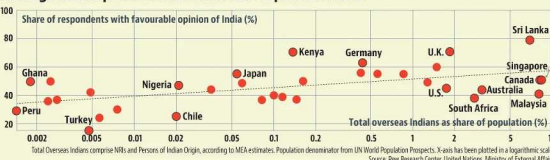
Source: Pew Research Center. The chart only includes 50 countries each with the lowest and highest share of respondents who opted to not offer either a favourable or unfavourable opinion of India. Data based on survey conducted from February 9 to May 13, 2026.

4 The diaspora dividend is real, but patchy

India's vast diaspora is often touted as soft power in reserve. The numbers suggest there is something to this claim, but hardly a guarantee. Countries with larger overseas Indian populations generally tend to view India more favourably, but the exceptions are hard to miss. Canada, Malaysia and Singapore all have overseas Indians (and people of Indian origin) who account for around 8% of the population, but India's favourability

ranges from 41% in Malaysia to 51% in the other two. In Sri Lanka, where the share is nearly 7%, the favourability is 79%. Meanwhile, the UK and South Africa offer another useful contrast. Indians make up 1.8% of UK's population and 2.8% of S Africa's, but favourability towards India is 71% in the former and just 38% in the latter. In Kenya, where 71% respondents had a favourable view, overseas Indians account for barely 0.1% of the population.

India's global diaspora delivers an uneven soft-power dividend



Total Overseas Indians comprise NRIs and Persons of Indian Origin, according to MEA estimates. Population denominator from UN World Population Prospects. X-axis has been plotted in a logarithmic scale. Source: Pew Research Center, United Nations, Ministry of External Affairs.



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2 VESSELS WITH 22 INDIANS ON BOARD HIJACKED OFF YEMEN, SOMALIA

MUMBAI: Pirates hijacked two commercial vessels carrying a total of 22 Indians in separate incidents off Yemen and Somalia, officials said Thursday. Six armed pirates hijacked the Eritrean-flagged oil tanker MT Sibul 1 in the Gulf of Aden, about 30 nautical miles off the Yemen coast. It was carrying 16 Indians among its 20 crew members. In the second incident, pirates seized the Cameroon-flagged cargo vessel MV Lutru, which was carrying six Indians among its crew, off Somalia. **HRC**

TOP COURT REFINES 'INDUSTRY' TEST BUT PROTECTS PENDING DISPUTES

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday, by a 5-4 majority, refined the expansive test laid down nearly five decades ago to determine what constitutes an "industry" under the now-repealed Industrial Disputes Act, while unanimously protecting all pending disputes from the impact of the new formulation. **HRC**

Wide mandate for July 20 probe panel

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday constituted a five-member committee headed by its former judge R Subhash Reddy to conduct an independent inquiry into allegations of violence during the July 20 student protests while looking into far-reaching issues such as pellet gun use, mandatory uniforms for law enforcement personnel during crowd control, blanket prohibitory orders, the legality of police surveillance, and whether a BNS provision was stifling dissent. A bench, comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joydipya Bagchi and V Mohana, said the competing allegations made out a prima facie case for an independent and impartial investigation into allegations of excessive and disproportionate use of force by police and security personnel during the July 20 student protests, while also examining claims of violence against police personnel and damage to public property. The committee comprises **HRC**

Key issues under examination

Police use of pellet guns, electric batons, lathi charges and tear gas without adequate warning or proportionality. Inquire into surveillance of protesters and whether it violated privacy and assembly rights. Give priority to allegations of targeted violence, harassment and molestation of women protesters. Whether police response during protests struck a balance between public order and the right to peaceful dissent. Whether pellet guns fired from pump-action rifles should be banned.

HC stays Soren govt order cancelling JPSC, FSO exam

Raj Kumar
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RANCHI: The Jharkhand High Court on Thursday stayed the notifications cancelling the 11th and 54 under the Food Safety Officer recruitment — affected by the cancellation. **HRC**

3 CONG-RULED STATES TO MOVE SC AGAINST MINES LAW AMENDMENT

Saubbhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: Three Congress-ruled states—Karnataka, Kerala and Telangana—are set to appeal in the Supreme Court against The Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment law that was cleared by Parliament this month. The law prohibits states from imposing levies over mineral rights or mineral bearing lands. **HRC**

CENTRE ALLOWS DUTY-FREE RAW SUGAR IMPORTS TO CURB PRICES

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NEW DELHI: In another attempt to contain surging sugar prices, the Centre on Thursday allowed 1 million tonnes of raw sugar to be imported duty-free under a tariff-rate quota (TRQ) until October 31. The last time India allowed the import of raw sugar was during the 2016-17 season. The move comes as supplies tighten ahead of India's peak-sugar-demand period from August to November. **HRC**

South CMs talk water, delimitation with Shah

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CHENNAI: Chief ministers of southern states on Thursday discussed regional water disputes, parliamentary delimitation demands, and more devolution of funds in proportion to their central tax pool contribution in a regional council meeting chaired by Union home minister Amit Shah. At the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council in Mahabalipuram, Karnataka **HRC**

chief minister DK Shivakumar backed the controversial Mekkadatu project. Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay underlined the rights of lower riparian states. Kerala CM VD Satheesan said his state would fund the Mullaperiyar dam. Telangana deputy CM Bharti Vikramarka Mallu called for resolving Krishna river water dispute with Andhra Pradesh, and Andhra Pradesh CM Chandrababu Naidu proposed a Godavari-Cauvery river-linking project. **HRC**

"If great rivers of India, from Brahmaputra to Cauvery and Godavari, are interconnected, India may not face any water shortage for the next 100 years." —AMIT SHAH, UNION HOME MINISTER

UGC equity rules under review: Centre tells SC

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NEW DELHI: The Centre on Thursday told the Supreme Court that it is reconsidering the University Grants Commission's (UGC) 2026 regulations on promoting equity in higher educational institutions, which the court had kept in abeyance in January after finding them "vague" and capable of "misuse". **HRC**

SHAH SLAMS CONG MOVE TO NOT SING NAT'L SONG IN FULL

NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Thursday launched a scathing attack on the Congress over its decision to sing only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram at party events, calling it "anti-national" and accusing the party of pursuing vote-bank appeasement. "In 1937, the Congress Party, for the sake of Muslim appeasement, split Vande Mataram...laying the foundation for the country's partition," Shah said. **HRC**

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SPORT | AFTER 4-MONTH LAYOFF

Alcaraz to return at US Open after injury



Carlos Alcaraz will return to competitive tennis at the U.S. Open, ending a more than four-month absence caused by a wrist injury, in a bid to defend his title in New York. The seven-times Grand Slam champion confirmed on Thursday that he will play the August 30 - September 13 tournament after withdrawing from the Barcelona Open in April and missing the French Open, Wimbledon and the North American hard-court events in Toronto and Cincinnati. New York holds particular significance for Alcaraz. He won his first Grand Slam title at Flushing Meadows in 2022.

WORLD | VETERAN BNP LEADER

Alamgir elected as president of B'desh



Bangladeshi lawmakers elected veteran Bangladesh Nationalist Party leader Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir as the country's new president on Thursday, making the longtime opposition figure the head of state after his party came to power in a major political transition. Alamgir, 78, defeated Oli Ahmed, a retired army colonel and chairman of the Liberal Democratic Party and candidate of the Jamaat-e-Islami-led 11-party opposition alliance in a parliamentary vote.

MY INDIA | IN MEETING WITH GOVT SECRETARIES

Modi calls for greater youth engagement by government



Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday called for greater engagement between government departments, universities and young people to bring fresh perspectives in policymaking. Chairing the third high-level meeting with Secretaries to the Government of India, Modi also sought effective use of AI while ensuring human intervention and judgement. He urged the secretaries to think with a long-term perspective on how the country's future should be shaped, a statement issued by the Prime Minister's office said.

WORLD | COMPLIES WITH U.S. CURBS

Nvidia to ship AI chip for China by year-end



Nvidia plans to start shipping small volumes of an AI chip designed for Chinese customers by year-end. The Information reported on Thursday. Several Chinese customers have already ordered the chip, a version of Nvidia's language processing unit, which uses technology licensed from Groq and works alongside Nvidia's graphics processors to speed up AI chatbot responses, the report said. The chip complies with US export controls, it said, though it remains unclear whether Beijing will approve sales.

WORLD | IN SOKOTO

50 killed after boat capsizes in Nigeria



At least 50 people, mostly children, died after an overloaded boat capsized on Thursday in Nigeria's northwest Sokoto state, witnesses said. The accident took place near Goro in Goro local government area and rescue efforts are continuing, said Abdulkadir Yusuf, an area manager at the National Inland Waterways Authority. A Reuters witness saw 50 bodies lying in the forecourt of a community mosque ahead of their burial in Goro later on Thursday. Nasiru Adamu, a lawmaker at the Sokoto state legislature, said that those aboard were mostly aged between 10 and 15 years old.

China sentences property tycoon Hui to life in jail

Agence France-Presse

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BEIJING: China sentenced the founder of embattled property giant Evergrande to life in prison and fined the group more than \$2 billion on Thursday for offences including fraud, five years after a high-profile default.

Evergrande Group was once the face of Chinese real estate, surging a decade-long property boom as it peddled home-ownership dreams.

But its access to credit dramatically narrowed when the government introduced curbs on excessive borrowing and speculation.

The company defaulted in 2021 after struggling to repay creditors. On Thursday, a court in southern China fined the firm and its real estate arm a total of 15.82 billion yuan (\$2.4 billion).

It issued a life sentence against founder Xu Hui, also known as Hui Ka Yan in Cantonese, for crimes including "large-scale financial fraud", the Shenzhen Intermediate People's Court in Guangdong province said in a post on its WeChat account.

"Xu Hui was sentenced for multiple crimes and fined, received a life sentence, with political rights revoked for life and all his personal property confiscated," it said.

Between 2016 and 2021, Evergrande and Xu's loss "violated national laws by engaging in continuous, large-scale financial fraud and other means to inflate assets and conceal liabilities", the court said.

It added that the parties "gained



Hui Ka Yan

control of financial institutions" through bribery, without naming the institutions.

Xu pleaded guilty in April to charges that also included embezzlement and bribery, the court said at the time.

The verdict caps 67-year-old Xu's spectacular fall from grace. He was once one of China's richest billionaires and a member of the Communist Party's top political advisory body.

On Thursday, a before-and-after photograph was being widely shared on social media — the older image, taken years ago, shows Xu beaming as he was chased by reporters, sporting jet black hair and wearing a gold chain.

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A royal reunion?

Prince Harry and his wife, Meghan, will return to the United Kingdom, seemingly marking the end to a yearslong rift between them and the royal family. Here is a timeline of recent events involving Harry and the British royal family.

July 2016: Prince Harry and American actor Meghan Markle met on a blind date set up by a mutual friend.

Nov 8, 2016: Harry confirms Markle is his girlfriend and condemns press coverage of her.

Nov 27, 2017: Harry and Meghan announce their engagement.

May 19, 2018: Meghan and Harry get married in a grand ceremony at Windsor Castle.

2019 onwards: Harry launches lawsuits against three newspaper groups - Rupert Murdoch's News Group, the Mirror Group and Associated Newspapers.

February 2020: The committee that oversees royal security decides Harry will not receive the same level of



May 6, 2019: Harry and Meghan's son Archie is born.

Jan 8, 2020: Harry and Meghan announce they plan to "step back" as senior royals and become financially independent. The decision soon becomes a major rift, and the couple moves to Meghan's native California.

June 4, 2021: Meghan and Harry's daughter Lilibet is born.

Sept 8, 2022: Queen Elizabeth II dies, aged 96, after 70 years on the throne. Her eldest son becomes King Charles III.

May 6, 2023: King Charles is crowned at Westminster Abbey. Harry attends without Meghan or the children.

Dec 5, 2023: A court hearing begins on Harry's claim over his security.

taxpayer-funded protection as he did when he was a full-time royal. Harry later launches legal action against the UK government.

June 4, 2021: Meghan and Harry's daughter Lilibet is born.

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May 6, 2023: King Charles is crowned at Westminster Abbey. Harry attends without Meghan or the children.

Dec 5, 2023: A court hearing begins on Harry's claim over his security.

Jan 10, 2023: Harry's ghost-written memoir "Spare" is published and becomes a bestseller. It recounts Harry's grief at the death of his mother when he was 12, his frustrations in his royal role and anger at his father, brother, stepmother and the media, among others.

Feb 5, 2024: Buckingham Palace announces that King Charles has cancer and will receive treatment.

Feb 7, 2024: Prince Harry arrives in the UK from California to visit his father.

Feb 28, 2024: The High Court dismisses Harry's security claim. He appeals the decision.

Jan 22, 2025: The publisher of tabloid newspaper The Sun settles a lawsuit, offering Harry "a full and unequivocal apology" for intruding on his private life.

May 2, 2025: Three Court of Appeal judges dismiss Harry's case, saying the security decision was "sensible".

Sept 10, 2025: Harry joins King Charles for tea in London, marking the first time they've met in more than a year.

July 10, 2026: King Charles hosts Harry and meets with his family for the first time in years as they try to repair the rift.

Aug 19, 2026: Plans are revealed that Harry and Meghan will return to the UK, but they won't resume their roles as working members of the royal family.

Princess Catherine, Prince William, Prince Harry and Meghan Markle after the passing of Queen Elizabeth II in 2022.

India's domestic air passenger traffic down 4.8% in July

Neha LM Tripathi

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NEW DELHI: Domestic air passenger traffic fell 4.8% to 12 million in July from 12.6 million last year, with most major airlines also reporting lower passenger load factors, according to Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) data released on Thursday.

Despite the July decline, passenger traffic during the first seven months of 2026 remained marginally higher than the corresponding period last year.

Indian airlines carried 98.4 million passengers during January-July, compared with 97.78 million a year earlier, an increase of 0.64%.

IndiGo, India's largest airline, carried 8.08 million passengers in July, down from 8.92 million in June. The Air India Group, comprising Air India and Air India Express, carried 2.88 million passengers, compared with 3.22 million in June.

Despite the fall in passenger numbers, IndiGo's market share rose to 67.4% in July from 66.3% in June, while the Air India group's share edged up to 24% from 23.9%.

Akasa Air's market share fell to 6.4% in July, compared with 6.8% in June. The passenger load factor — the proportion of available

DESPITE THE JULY DECLINE, PASSENGER TRAFFIC DURING THE FIRST SEVEN MONTHS OF 2026 REMAINED SLIGHTLY HIGHER THAN IN THE CORRESPONDING PERIOD LAST YEAR

seats occupied — declined for IndiGo, the Air India Group and Akasa Air during the month. SpiceJet was the exception, with its load factor rising to 74.7% in July from 73.2% in June.

The overall cancellation rate of scheduled domestic airlines was 0.62% in July. Technical issues accounted for 39.9% of cancellations, followed by operational reasons at 27.4% and weather-related disruptions at 22.7%, according to the DGCA.

IndiGo recorded the highest on-time performance (OTP) among scheduled domestic airlines at 10 major airports, at 91.2%, followed by Akasa Air at 90.8% and the Air India Group at 88.5%.

Alliance Air recorded an OTP of 78%, while SpiceJet had the lowest at 34.6%.

The airports covered in the OTP assessment were Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Kolkata, Hyderabad, Chennai, Ahmedabad, Cochin, Guwahati and Lucknow.

Rupee exports get equal footing with dollar, euro

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: The government on Thursday put export earnings received in Indian rupees on the same footing as those received in freely convertible currencies such as the US dollar and euro for availing benefits under the Foreign Trade Policy (FTP), in a move that could encourage greater use of the rupee in international trade.

The change means eligible exporters receiving payment in rupees through approved banking channels will be able to claim FTP benefits, for which those receipts towards their export obligations, as they would with eligible foreign-currency earnings.

The Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) amended the FTP 2023 with immediate effect, aligning its provisions with the Reserve Bank of India's Foreign Exchange Management (Manner of Receipt and Payment) Regulations, 2023.

The facility for rupee-denominated export transactions was first introduced in November 2022. Thursday's notification expands its scope and aligns it with the FTP introduced in April 2023.

The move could make rupee settlement more attractive for Indian exporters by reducing currency-conversion costs and exchange-rate risks. It could also help expand trade with



The move could make rupee settlement more attractive for Indian exporters and help expand trade with countries facing shortages of dollars.

countries facing shortages of dollars or difficulties accessing established international payment systems.

Ajay Srivastava, founder of the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI), said the notification "removes uncertainty" and "places eligible rupee export receipts on par" with foreign-currency earnings.

"Earlier, exporters receiving rupee payments through an RBI-approved banking channel were not always certain whether such receipts would qualify for FTP benefits or count towards their export obligations.

The new rules remove this uncertainty by placing eligible rupee receipts on par with foreign-currency earnings," he said.

The broader significance is that Indian exporters and overseas buyers now have greater scope to settle transactions in rupees rather than relying on the dollar or another freely convertible currency, Srivastava said.

But the policy change by itself will not lead to large-scale rupee trade, he cautioned.

"Foreign buyers must be able to obtain rupees easily, while overseas banks need practical options to use, invest, convert or repatriate their balances," he said.

India would need country-specific settlement arrangements, simpler banking procedures, affordable hedging, rupee-based export credit and export-credit insurance to make rupee settlement commercially viable, Srivastava said.

"Without this supporting system, rupee invoicing may remain a useful facility rather than becoming a widely used trade option," he added.

The rules continue to provide separate treatment for countries covered by the Asian Clearing Union (ACU), as well as Nepal and Bhutan.

For ACU members, contracts generally have to be denominated in an ACU-approved currency, subject to applicable RBI directions.

The latest notification brings the trade-policy framework in line with the RBI's 2023 foreign-exchange regulations, which widened the scope for using the rupee in cross-border trade.

Govt allows duty-free import of raw sugar to curb surging prices

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NEW DELHI: In another attempt to contain surging sugar prices, the Centre on Thursday allowed 1 million tonnes of raw sugar to be imported duty-free under a tariff-rate quota (TRQ) until October 31.

The government's notification, however, allows only raw sugar to be imported, which must first be refined before it can reach the market as white sugar.

The last time India allowed the import of raw sugar was during the 2016-17 season.

The move comes as supplies tighten ahead of India's peak sugar demand period, which runs broadly from August through November, when festivals such as Ganesh Chaturthi, Dussehra and Diwali lift demand from households, sweet shops and food companies. The order comes on the heels of sugar prices surging to new peaks. Sugar prices in key Karnataka markets rose to as much as ₹7,000 per 100kg on Thursday.

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expected a larger release to meet rising festive demand.

On Wednesday, the government tightened the rules further, saying bulk consumers using more than 10 tonnes a month will be allowed to import up to 15 days' requirements until November 30.

The latest move therefore marks a significant escalation: instead of only existing stock into the market, the government is now seeking to add to domestic supply.

The government, in a statement, said the move "will immediately dispel speculation and ensure adequate supply to consumers at reasonable and stable prices over the coming year."

However, the imported raw sugar will not reach consumers immediately.

According to GK Sood, chairman of KGN Agri Resources Ltd, the process itself means imported sugar cannot reach the market immediately. "The government would first need a few days to allocate the TRQ among mills willing

to take the raw sugar. The mills would then have to scour the market, sign contracts and make payment arrangements. This would be followed by finding a vessel and securing a loading slot in Brazil, with the voyage alone taking at least a month. Once the sugar arrives in India, unloading can take about 25 days for a 50,000-tonne shipment. If operations are not disrupted by rain, the sugar then has to be transported to mills, where refining capacity is typically only 500-700 tonnes a day. So it is a slow process," he said, adding that these steps together determine the lead time before imported sugar can reach the domestic market. He sees only 200,000-300,000 tonnes of sugar entering the market by the end of the allotted import window.

Raw sugar from Brazil is estimated at around ₹45 per kg and could cost about ₹52 per kg after refining in India, according to Pragful Vithalani, chairman, All India Sugar Trade Association. "This will kill the fear and speculation if any," he said.

The urgency in government steps reflects a supply issue that has become considerably tighter than the government's earlier projections. About 3 million tonnes of sugar was diverted to ethanol production during the current season, while around 100,000 tonnes was exported, although the government had allowed a total export quota of 2 million tonnes. The Centre eventually stopped exports in May as domestic availability became a concern.

Govt hands over illegal drug racket case to SIT

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government on Thursday ordered a special investigation team (SIT) probe into a suspected interstate illegal drug racket allegedly involved in repackaging and relabelling medicines under the names of reputed multinational brands, officials said.

The decision comes days after officials from the Drug Enforcement Wing of the Karnataka Food Safety and Drug Administration department raided an authorised pharmaceutical facility at Kurubarakeralahalli near Bidadi in Bengaluru South District.

The six-member team will be headed by C Vamshikrishna, joint commissioner of police, West, Bengaluru city, they said.

According to an order, the other members are Shiva Prakash Narayana, superintendent of police (CID); Manjunath Reddy, assistant drugs controller (Bengaluru); Namritha Hallur, assistant drugs controller (Bengaluru South District); and Neha Murug, drugs inspector (Bengaluru South District). The team will submit periodic progress reports to the ADGP, Law and Order, who will forward them to the DG and IGP, the order said.

The SIT will conduct a com-

THE SIX-MEMBER TEAM WILL BE HEADED BY C VAMSHIKRISHNA, JOINT COMMISSIONER OF POLICE, WEST, BENGALURU CITY, THE ORDER SAID

prehensive investigation into the case and any other cases that may be registered across the state in connection with the matter. It will submit its investigation report to the competent court and send a copy to the government through the DG&IGP, it added.

The raid reportedly uncovered a large-scale operation involving the illegal repackaging and relabelling of medicines. Four people have already been arrested in connection with the case, while investigators suspect that the alleged kingpin is currently hiding abroad. The team has been tasked with conducting a detailed investigation into the network, its financial transactions, supply chain and those allegedly involved in manufacturing and distributing the counterfeit medicines.

Health minister UT Khader and home minister G Parameshwara had earlier indicated that the government was considering an SIT investigation

following the discovery of the racket.

Khader had said the authorities were particularly concerned over the alleged manufacture of counterfeit injections, including medicines used in intensive care units.

"Medicines from other states and countries were allegedly brought here and labels of multinational companies were put on them before they were sold. Even ICU medicines have been counterfeited. We need to find out which hospitals and medical stores received these products and whether patients were affected," he said.

According to officials, the Drug Enforcement Wing conducted the raid on August 18 at an unlicensed pharmaceutical manufacturing facility located at No. 34, Kurubarakeralahalli village, near Bidadi.

During the operation, officials allegedly seized counterfeit medicines, bulk stocks, packaging machinery, empty vials and fake labels. The total estimated value of the materials seized has been put at around ₹5.05 crore.

The investigation has raised serious concerns because the alleged racket was reportedly supplying fake injections and tablets using the names and packaging of reputed multinational pharmaceutical companies.

'State to recommend rejection of draft on Kasturirangan report'

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government will recommend rejection of the draft notification based on the Kasturirangan report on the Western Ghats, forest minister Ramalinga Reddy told the Legislative Assembly on Thursday.

The issue was raised during a discussion under Rule 69 by Vijayprakash MLA and chief minister Ponnanna, who highlighted concerns among farmers and residents of Kodagu and other Malnad districts over the latest draft notification to declare ecologically sensitive areas and restricting activities such as mining, quarrying and certain large infrastructure and industrial projects.

The proposed restrictions have triggered opposition from residents and elected representatives in several Western Ghats districts, who fear that stringent environmental regulations could affect agriculture, construction, infrastructure development and livelihoods.

The Karnataka government's decision to recommend rejection is expected to strengthen its stand against implementation of the report in the state, has 60 days to submit its objections to the draft notification.

The Kasturirangan committee constituted to study the spread opinion to the Gadgil report on protecting the West-



Ramalinga Reddy

ern Ghats. The Gadgil committee submitted report on August 11, 2011 while Kasturirangan committee submitted report on April 15, 2013.

Kasturirangan committee recommended declaring ecologically sensitive areas and restricting activities such as mining, quarrying and certain large infrastructure and industrial projects.

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STIR INTENSIFIES IN CAUVERY BASIN OVER RELEASE OF WATER FROM KRS

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BENGALURU/MANDYA: Protests intensified in the Cauvery basin, especially in Mandya on Thursday, as farmers alleged that a huge amount of water is being released from the KRS dam to Tamil Nadu.

The Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) had upheld the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) recommendation of releasing 12,000 cusecs of water for 15 days starting from August 12. The Tamil Nadu government has approached the Supreme Court seeking a direction for Karnataka to respect the CWMA's order, sources said.

At Sanjay Circle in Mandya, farmers staged sit-in demonstration. Kannada Sena activists extended support to the farmers' organisation's protest and blocked the old Bengaluru-Mysuru highway. The protesters charged there was only 109 feet of water in the dam and questioned the decision to release water to Tamil Nadu despite this. Leading the protest, Kannada activist Vatal Nagappa alleged that the government was supporting the agitation to end across a strong message to all over the country. Mandya MLA Ravi Kumar Gowda (Ganiga) demanded that the release of water to Tamil Nadu be stopped.

Speaking at the Cauvery Irrigation Advisory Committee met held on Wednesday, Gowda questioned how water could be denied to Karnataka's farmers.

Committed to protect interests of TN on Mekedatu issue: CMs

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CHENNAI: Karnataka chief minister D K Shivakumar on Thursday said that he has given a commitment in the presence of Union home minister Amit Shah here that the interests of Tamil Nadu and Puducherry will be protected in the proposed Mekedatu dam issue.

Speaking to reporters after taking part in the southern CMs meeting at Kovilambur near here that was chaired by Shah, Shivakumar said he has favoured a separate meeting to amicably settle water-sharing issues. The meeting was attended by CMs C Joseph Vijay (Tamil Nadu), V D Satheesan (Kerala) and N Chandrababu Naidu (Andhra Pradesh) among others.

Except for using five TMC (thousand million cubic ft) for drinking water requirements, the rest of the water stored in the proposed Mekedatu dam will be for Tamil Nadu, he said. "I have given a commitment

to the state of Tamil Nadu before the home minister that whatever Mekedatu dam that is there, even if there is a single drop of water; except for five TMC for drinking water, the rest of the water will be left to Tamil Nadu itself from the Mekedatu dam; so Tamil Nadu and Puducherry shall be rest assured, the dam will be built only for you not for us," the CM said.

Earlier, addressing the Southern Zonal Council meeting, Shivakumar flagged the issue of the Mekedatu project, stressing that it is an important initiative not only for Karnataka, but for Tamil Nadu as well.

"While walking to the meeting, senior leader and Andhra Pradesh chief minister Chandrababu Naidu ji told me that we need to solve the Cauvery water issue between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu. Let me assure you, every drop of water from the Mekedatu project will help farmers in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry. Help us to help you," he said.



CM DK Shivakumar with Tamil Nadu CM Joseph Vijay in Chengalpattu on Thursday.

Shivakumar said rivers such as the Cauvery, Krishna, Tungabhadra, Pennar and Palar were the lifelines of the southern peninsula and calling for a shift from "water sharing to water cooperation".

"Our rivers do not recognise political boundaries," he said. "Water must unite us, not divide us. The time has come to move from water sharing to water cooperation. Karnataka has shown what that cooperation looks like," he said.

Referring to the June 25 meeting involving Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, he said the three states had demonstrated that interstate water issues could be addressed through dialogue.

The three states then discussed resolving the water sharing issue between them amicably, and decided to find a permanent solution to the water crisis with the involvement of Union minister for Jal Shakti C R Patil.

"We accept that every riparian state has legitimate needs. And our stand rests on three principles: equity, transparency, cooperation," he said.

At the same time, Shivakumar said, the cooperation must be reciprocal and Karnataka's lawful share under tribal awards and timely completion of projects benefiting its farmers must be protected. Mekedatu is a multi-purpose project proposed by Karnataka, which involves building a balancing reservoir near Kanakapura in Ramnagar district.

Tamil Nadu has been opposing the project, raising apprehensions that the state would be affected if the project takes shape.

The project, once completed, is aimed at ensuring drinking water to Bengaluru and neighbouring areas (4.75 tmcft); it also can generate 400 MW power, and the estimated cost of the project is ₹9,000 crore (2019 rates), according to Karnataka officials.

Terming the meeting involving Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana in June as a "historic landmark" in interstate water relations, Shivakumar said the three states had demonstrated that interstate water issues could be addressed through dialogue.

"Chandrababu Naidu and Revanth Reddy, the chief ministers of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, sat with me at that table, and we spoke as partners, not as competitors. That is the Karnataka approach," he said.

Festive cheer in the city



Crowd thronged KR Market in Bengaluru on Thursday to buy fresh flowers and fruits ahead of Varamahalakshmi festival.

No cases of foreigners getting Aadhaar: Min

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BENGALURU: Karnataka home minister Priyank Kharge told the legislature that no cases of Pakistanis, Bangladeshis, or Iranians obtaining Aadhaar cards, ration cards, or other government benefits have been reported during the ongoing SIR of the electoral roll in the state. The minister said this in a written reply to a question by expelled BJP MLA Basanagouda Patil Yatal.

"During the ongoing SIR (of electoral roll) process in the state, no cases have been reported of Pakistanis, Bangladeshis, or Iranians obtaining Aadhaar cards, ration cards, or other government benefits," Kharge said.

Yatal had asked whether the serious issue of Pakistani, Bangladeshi, and Iranian nationals

allegedly possessing Aadhaar cards, ration cards, and other government benefits and being registered as voters has come to the government's notice during the ongoing SIR process in the state? If so, how many such unauthorised posters featuring the state? The SIR enumeration process concluded on August 17, with the draft electoral rolls scheduled for publication on August 24. As many as 1.07 crore voters have been categorised under Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate and Others (ASDDO).

Meanwhile, in a reply to a question in the Legislative Council, the Home Minister said the exact number of foreigners who have illegally entered the country and are residing in the state is unavailable. However, over the past three years, a total of 911 illegal immigrants have been identified in the state.

HC reserves order on plea by Siddaramaiah, DKS seeking to quash defamation case

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka High Court on Thursday reserved its order on the petitions filed by chief minister DK Shivakumar and former chief minister Siddaramaiah seeking quashing of a defamation case registered against them over advertisements published by the Congress ahead of the 2023 Assembly elections.

Justice M Nagaprassanna, who heard the petitions, reserved the order after completing arguments from both sides.

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reputation before voters. The advertisements allegedly contributed to the BJP losing 40 Assembly constituencies and resulted in around 10% of its votes shifting away, the counsel submitted, urging the court not to quash the proceedings.

Senior advocate Shashikiran Shetty, appearing for the petitioners, argued that the complainant had not obtained the required authorisation from the party's national unit before filing the private complaint.

He also pointed out that proceedings against Congress leader Rahul Gandhi in the same matter had already been quashed and sought similar relief for Shivakumar and Siddaramaiah.

The dispute dates back to the 2023 Assembly election campaign, when corruption was a major issue raised by the Congress against the BJP government.

The Congress published front-page advertisements titled "corruption rate card", alleging that bribes had been fixed for various government works.

The advertisements alleged that commissions ranging from 25 to 30 per cent were being collected in areas including supply of Covid-19 materials, Public Works Department contracts, grants to religious institutions, supply of eggs to schools and road projects.

THREE F.I.R.s OVER UNAUTHORISED POSTERS OF MIN

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BENGALURU: Three FIRs were registered for allegedly pasting unauthorised posters featuring Greater Bengaluru Development Minister Krishna Byre Gowda on public walls, police said on Thursday.

The cases were registered following complaints filed by civic authorities under the Greater Bengaluru Authority on August 19, they said. Two of the three FIRs were registered against a person identified as Shivakumar within the limits of Yelahanka and Kodigehalli grants to religious institutions, supply of eggs to schools and road projects.

Officials crack down on illegal chemical banana ripening units in Udipi village

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MANGALURU/UDUPI: A team of officials led by the assistant commissioner of the Kundapur subdivision in Udipi district raided multiple locations in Alore, a village following reports of an illegal chemical banana-ripening network on Thursday morning.

During the raid, authorities seized 5,000 kg of raw banana bunches valued at ₹4 lakh, along with chemicals, artificial colours, and equipment used for artificial ripening. Police registered a case under the Prevention of Food Adulteration Act, 1954, following the seizure of the illegal chemical banana-ripening network on Thursday morning.



Authorities seized 5,000 kg of raw bananas valued at ₹4 lakh.

Rashmi said that the raid started simultaneously in three locations on Thursday morning. During the operation, authorities discovered that traders were using harmful chemicals and artificial colouring agents to artificially ripen bananas. Officials seized ripening chemicals, colouring substances, processing equipment, and vehicles involved in the illicit operation.

When asked if their conscience allowed them to compromise public health, one of the officers said they had been carrying out the same operation for the past 20 years. He explained that the illegal operation utilized two primary methods: dipping raw banana bunches into drums filled with chemical solutions or spraying chemicals directly onto the produce. These chemicals reportedly cost between ₹2,000 and ₹4,000 per unit. The chemical application causes raw bananas to ripen overnight or within two days before distribution.

Useage since 2016 In 2016, the Principal Civil Judge Court in Udipi issued an injunction against an illegal banana storage warehouse operating near residential homes in Ramprasad-Kemthur Road. Local resident M Sharath Kumar had filed a lawsuit in the Udipi court citing severe health issues among neighborhood residents. However, despite the court order a decade ago, the illicit trade continued.

SOPs for ripening Prof Idya Karunassagar, adviser at Nite University, and former food safety officer at the AO of the TN, based in Rome, explained that highly perishable fruits like mango, papaya, banana and others cannot be stored and transported over long distances so traders generally harvest raw fruits and ripen them artificially. The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) permits the use of ethylene gas for artificial ripening. However, due to its high cost and scarcity, traders often resort to unsafe and banned ripeners like carbide gas, which can be harmful to health, officials said.

Expired goods, fungal growth found at railway station eateries The teams inspected the railway pantry, hotel and food served on the train. The team found that Vande Bharat trains used and banned ripeners like carbide gas, which can be harmful to health, officials said.

EXPIRED GOODS, FUNGAL GROWTH FOUND AT RAILWAY STATION EATERIES

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BENGALURU: A special inspection conducted by the Food Safety and Drug Administration department of Karnataka at food establishments in 36 railway stations on Thursday revealed the suspected use of non-permitted colours in sweets, expired dairy products and food items, and fungal growth in vegetables.

The inspection was conducted at 112 food establishments at Bengaluru City Railway station (KSR), Yeshwanthpur, Krishna Raja Wodegar, Yelahanka, Kolar, Mysuru, Haveri, Udipi, Koppal, Gadag, Davanagere, Bagalkote, Karwar, Yadgir, Beary and Kadur Junction, Ballari, Hospet, Hubballi and Mangaluru, a statement from the food safety department said.

The teams inspected the railway pantry, hotel and food served on the train. The team found that Vande Bharat trains used and banned ripeners like carbide gas, which can be harmful to health, officials said.

Assembly passes 3 bills amid Oppn protest seeking minister's removal

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka Legislative Assembly on Thursday passed three Bills, including the Bangalore Development Authority (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which cuts by up to 50 per cent the fee for registering properties in BDA-notified areas.

The other two Bills passed by the Assembly were the Nadaprabhu Kempegowda Heritage Area Development Authority (Amendment) Bill, 2026, and the Karnataka Town and Country Planning (Amendment) Bill, 2026.

All three Bills were passed amid protests by the BJP and JD(S), which demanded the resignation of Minister N Nagendra over corruption allegations against him.

ALL THREE BILLS WERE PASSED AMID PROTESTS BY THE BJP AND JD(S), DEMANDING THE RESIGNATION OF N NAGENDRA OVER CORRUPTION ALLEGATIONS

"Although land for these layouts was acquired several years ago, some unauthorised layouts and properties have since come up on the acquired land. We are currently unable to remove the residents from these properties, but at the same time, they are unable to obtain proper legal documents for their properties," he said.

The land had come under the control of the BDA, preventing residents from obtaining khata certificates and completing property documentation, he said. "We need to provide relief to these people and enable them to obtain permanent documentation and full ownership rights

over their properties. With this objective, we had previously issued guidelines and provided certain concessions. Now, we have brought another significant amendment to further reduce the applicable rates from 50 per cent to 25 per cent, Gowda said.

According to estimates, around 1.15 lakh unauthorised houses have been constructed on land acquired by the BDA, he said. Earlier, sites measuring 20x30 ft were subject to a charge equivalent to 10 per cent of the guidance value. The amendment reduces this to 5 per cent, Gowda said.

Similarly, for sites measuring more than 20x30 ft and up to 30x60 ft, the charge has been reduced from 50 per cent to 25 per cent of the guidance value, he said.

For sites measuring more than 30x60 ft and up to 50x80 ft, the charge has been reduced from 50 per cent to 25 per cent of the guidance value, he said.

Now erupts as Vijay seeks 'assurance' over delimitation

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: A row erupted in Tamil Nadu over the delimitation exercise after chief minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday urged the Centre to provide a "clear legislative assurance" that no state will suffer a reduction in its percentage of representation in Parliament.

The chief minister did not repeat the resolution passed in the assembly on August 12 which demanded permanent freezing of the 543 seats in the Lok Sabha or for permanently retaining the existing state wise allocation.

In his speech at the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council in Mahabalipuram, Vijay said, "I urge the Union government to provide a clear legislative assurance that no state will suffer a reduction in its percentage of representation in Parliament on account of its success in population stabilisation." Such an approach would uphold the principles of equity, preserve the federal balance envisioned by our Constitution, and reinforce the identity of all States as democratic institutions," he said.

The DMK slammed Vijay over the comments. "Chief minister C. Joseph Vijay flip-flops on the constituency delimitation issue,"



Union home minister Amit Shah with Tamil Nadu chief minister C. Joseph Vijay in Chengalpattu on Thursday. @MOTAMINADU

DMK spokesperson Saravanan Annadurai said, "The AIADMK also attacked the TVK government, stating that it has pulled off a complete 'U-Turn' on the Delimitation issue. 'What are you saying now is the exact same thing the Union government said. And that is why the AIADMK supported the delimitation bill when it was introduced,' the AIADMK IT Wing said on social media.

"Why conduct such a resolution drama just to flip-flop like this?" the party asked. Meanwhile, the IT wing of the TVK said, "In the speech delivered by the Chief Minister... a broad visionary perspective was presented to protect the current

representation of Southern states that have successfully implemented population control. The resolution passed in Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly on August 12 articulates this in actionable terms," it said.

"Despite this, misleading opinions are being spread about constituency delimitation without even a basic understanding of the issue," it added.

Talking to reporters outside the venue of the meeting, minister for energy resources and law, CTR Nirmal Kumar said, "There is no change in TVK's stance on the delimitation issue. There is no change in our position that the number of Lok Sabha seats should remain at 543."

Shah seeks backing of states to combat drugs

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: The Centre has prepared a three-year roadmap towards eradication of narcotics as a drug-free India is a necessity for every government and society. Union home and cooperation minister Amit Shah said on Thursday.

"It is the responsibility of all of us to contribute towards building an educated and healthy India," Shah said in his address at the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council in Mahabalipuram.

The roles of several departments of the Union government and the States have been defined in the roadmap, he said. "Until all the departments of the central and state governments join this movement, we will not be able to see the coming generation from this evil," he said.

Shah highlighted South India as a vital driver of the country's overall development, praising the region's consistent contributions across key sectors — literature, research and development,

space, IT, AI and agriculture.

"South India has played a very major role in all areas of the country's IT, automobiles, pharmaceuticals and infrastructure development, and that is why a large amount of foreign direct investment has also come to the South," he remarked.

Shah said the entire development journey of South India has been based on three pillars — high literacy rate, trained manpower and technical expertise in the utilisation of deep seas.

"These three pillars have made South India the biggest contributor to the country's development. The people of South India and the governments have also established many excellent traditions in the fields of innovation and revenue generation. The whole of India should learn from South India in these two areas," Shah said.

He emphasised that malnutrition and stunting should be closely focused on and that the fight against malnutrition was initiated by Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh which was eventually accepted across the country.

6-yr-old dies allegedly after teacher slaps him

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HYDERABAD: A six-year-old boy died after allegedly being slapped by his teacher for not completing his homework at a private school in Visakhapatnam on Thursday, police said.

The incident took place at Little Garden School in the One Town area. The victim was studying in upper kindergarten (UKG), and the accused has been identified as Anuradha, a language teacher.

A purported CCTV video from the classroom, which went viral on social media, showed the boy holding a state and standing in a line in front of the teacher. He appears to be crying and pleading with her not to beat him. The teacher is seen adjusting his uniform before pulling him closer and slapping him on the cheek. Within seconds, the boy collapses onto the teacher in the purported video, the veracity of which could not be independently verified by HT.

The teacher apparently alerted the other teachers, who rushed there and tried to do CPR on the student. Later, the school staff rushed him to a nearby hospital, but doctors were unable to revive him. Apparently, the boy had suffered a cardiac arrest out of panic, Visakhapatnam revenue divisional officer (RDO) Sudhakar Dileep Chakravarty told

OFFICIALS SAID A CASE HAS BEEN REGISTERED AND IT IS SUSPECTED THE STUDENT HAD A CARDIAC ARREST DUE TO PANIC

reporters.

The boy's body was later shifted to King George Hospital (KGH) the same day, for a post-mortem examination. "We shall order an inquiry into the matter," the RDO said.

King George Hospital superintendent Dr I Vani told HT that the boy had died by the time he was brought to the hospital around noon. "We cannot ignore the possibility that the boy suffered cardiac arrest due to panic or any other reason," she said.

"We will complete the post-mortem procedure by tomorrow. Only after the report comes out, we shall be able to tell the exact cause of death," Vani added.

The Visakhapatnam district education department has initiated an inquiry to determine the circumstances surrounding the boy's death and whether there was any negligence on the part of the school, people familiar with the matter said.

The boy's parents, who work in catering, and their relatives gathered outside the school on

Thursday evening after learning about his death. They staged a protest and alleged that the teacher's assault directly led to the tragedy.

"Our family went on a pilgrimage last week for a few days and returned only on Wednesday. That was the reason why he had not done the homework. He had no health issues at all," the boy's father said. "How can the teacher behave so rudely with a UKG student?" he added.

The boy's mother alleged that the school management did not inform them about the incident. "Without informing us, they directly took my son to the hospital, where he was declared dead," she alleged.

"We want strict action against the teacher and the management of the school," the mother added.

HT reached out to the school authorities and could not elicit a response by the time of going to print.

A police officer at One Town police station said, "A case of suspicious death has been registered on the boy's family's complaint in the matter. The investigation is underway."

"Stringent action will be taken against the school management. The government stands firmly with the victim's family," said state education minister Laxmi Lokesh in a post on X.

Min: Stay on shunting of teacher not setback

Press Trust of India
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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala's general education minister N. Samsudheen on Wednesday said a stay on suspension of a teacher, for framing a "wrong question" with regard to Hindu deity, was not a setback for the government.

The minister said that grant of interim stay was nothing extraordinary and was done in the normal course for such matters. The government will explain its court stand on the suspension of the teacher — Guruprasad Rai K — saying that it was not required for the proper conduct of the enquiry again in view of the nature of allegations he was facing.

At the same time, the court said that taking into consideration the allegation against Rai K, the enquiry shall continue.

Samsudheen also referred to the recent murder of an elderly man in Alappuzha district allegedly by teenagers as an isolated incident.

In order to curb such incidents, the education being imparted to children in schools includes advice and directions



N. Samsudheen

avoid violence and criminal acts. Such activities will be increased going forward, he said.

Four teenagers, including a 13-year-old girl, have been apprehended for allegedly killing an elderly man for money. The three other minors, friends of the accused girl, hailed from Paravur in Kollam district, police had said.

According to the police, Sivankutty was found dead inside his house on Monday morning while his wife and daughter were away at a hospital at the time.

The chain he was wearing and the gold kept in the house were reportedly missing.

Police said that they suspect the accused wanted to steal money to buy a high-end mobile and a bike and the murder occurred during the theft attempt.

4 OF FAMILY KILLED IN T'GANA AS CAR FALLS INTO WELL

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: Four members of a family, including two children, died after the car in which they were travelling plunged into an open well on the roadside in Telangana's Siddipet district in the wee hours of Thursday, police said.

The accident took place on the outskirts of Appannapalli village of Dubbak mandal. The car, a two-wheeler, was driven by a 35-year-old man, a businessman from Balwanthapur village, his wife Bhagya (25), their four-year-old son Nilansh and a two-year-old daughter Shrivika, police said.

According to a police officer from Dubbak, the family had travelled to Siddipet on Wednesday to attend the rituals of a close relative who died recently.

"After the programme, they left for their native village in their car at around 9 pm. However, when they did not reach home even late at night, their family members became worried and alerted the Dubbak police station," he said.

The four bodies were shifted to the regional hospital in Dubbak for autopsy. "The exact cause of the car losing control and plunging into the well is yet to be established. We have launched a probe into the circumstances that led to the accident," the police officer added.

Jagan challenges CM to order CBI probe into APPSC Group-I exams

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: YSR Congress Party president and former Andhra Pradesh chief minister YS Jagan Mohan Reddy on Thursday challenged Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu to order an inquiry by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) into the allegations of irregularities in the conduct of Group-I services (main) examination by the Andhra Pradesh Public Service Commission (APPSC) during the previous regime.

Speaking to reporters at the party office, Jagan demanded that the Naidu government, at the same time, should also order a CBI probe into the alleged irregularities in the conduct of teachers' recruitment through district selection committees

YS Jagan Mohan Reddy

(DSC) in 2025. "We are asking for the CBI investigation into the allegations on the APPSC Group-I services examination during our regime, because we had not committed any mistake. Does Naidu have the courage to order the CBI probe into the DSC-2025 examinations?"

Reacting to the allegations made by the chief minister during the discussion on APPSC Group-I (Mains) examinations in the state assembly on Wednesday, the YSRCP chief said the entire process was held in a transparent manner and as per the court's directives, leaving no room for any misappropriation.

He said the Group-I preliminary examinations were held in 2018 when Chandrababu Naidu was the chief minister in his earlier stint. "By making allegations of irregularities in their selection, the chief minister is putting the future of these 163 candidates in jeopardy," Jagan alleged.

"The allegations that the evaluation was done by non-qualified persons at Havildar Resorts or elsewhere are rubbish. No such thing was done in the glare of CCTV in the APPSC office and in educational institutions. It was done in a jumbling method and bar code was used, there was no scope of the evaluator knowing the aspirant," Jagan said.

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Telangana Cong issues notice to leaders over 'anti-CM' statements

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: The rift within the Telangana Congress intensified on Thursday as the party's disciplinary committee took strict action against several of its leaders over their "anti-party" and "anti-chief minister" remarks, people familiar with the matter said.

According to Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) chief B Mahesh Kumar, a show-cause notice was issued to leaders for the TPCC, including Konda Surekha, holding her responsible for her daughter Konda Sushmita's disparaging remarks against the party and chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu.

On Wednesday, Sushmita's remarks made during her mother's birthday celebrations at Parklane in Warangal district, triggered an uproar in the state Congress unit. Sushmita claimed that the Konda family had played a key role in projecting N. Chandrababu Naidu as the president's post and introducing him to the Congress high command.

"After becoming the chief minister, power has gone to his head and he has forgotten those who supported him during his political rise," she alleged.

The PCDC disciplinary committee headed by Nigam Kumar Malu Ravi, who condemned Sushmita's comments, also issued show-cause notice to former minister and Telangana state planning board vice-chairman G Chinnappa Reddy for allegedly accusing the state Congress leadership of selling tickets in the last assembly elections.



Konda Surekha

Besides, the PC on Thursday suspended senior Congress leader Jakkidi Prabhakar Reddy, the father of Telangana Youth Congress president Jakkidi Shashank Kumar, for allegedly making personal and caste-related remarks against senior party leaders.

The committee also issued show-cause notices to Adilabad assembly constituency party in-charge Kandi Srinivas Reddy and party leader Sanjay Reddy over alleged objectionable remarks made against party leaders during a DCC Political Affairs Committee meeting in Utnoor.

"These leaders have been asked to submit their explanations within three days. The Congress high command has taken serious note of the rising voices of rebellion within the Telangana Congress in the recent past. The party views these comments as a violation of the party line," Mahesh Kumar Gould told reporters in Nizamabad.

Malu Ravi, who condemned Sushmita's comments, also issued show-cause notice to former minister and Telangana state planning board vice-chairman G Chinnappa Reddy for allegedly accusing the state Congress leadership of selling tickets in the last assembly elections.

Kerala child rights panel seeks transparency in contest judging

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala child rights panel has directed that the marks awarded by judges to contestants and groups at school arts festival competitions be displayed on electronic screens on the stage to ensure greater transparency in the judging process.

The State Commission for Protection of Child Rights also directed the authorities to collect money from students of Classes 1 to 8 or their parents in the name of the school arts festival, according to a statement on Thursday.

The directions were issued by a full bench of the Commission comprising Chairperson K V Manoj Kumar and members B Mohankumar, K K Shaji and Dr F Wilson on complaints related to the conduct of school Kalosavaram (arts festival).

The Commission said it had noticed widespread collection of money in the conduct of the festival from the school level to the state level. It directed that the Kalosavaram manual be revised by including people with expertise in the field. The names and mobile phone numbers of programme convenors and contest-judges should be displayed at venues so that contest-

SCPCR DIRECTED AUTHORITIES NOT TO TAKE MONEY FROM STUDENTS OF CLASSES 1 TO 8 OR THEIR PARENTS IN THE NAME OF SCHOOL ARTS FEST

ants and the public can easily access them, the commission said. It also directed authorities to make suitable arrangements for children with disabilities by identifying events in which they can participate and providing accessible classrooms and other facilities.

The commission said eligible judges from the panel of the Cultural Affairs Department should also be considered while appointing judges.

Criteria should be framed for selecting judges, and their names and their educational qualifications, and expertise should be displayed on screens during competitions from the sub-district to state levels. It said that judges should not move away or sit together while judging.

Judges should not communicate with one another or use electronic devices such as mobile phones, tablets and smart watches for any form of e-communication until they complete their duty, it said.

On appeals, the body said orders should be issued within three days of the appeal, and the reasons for the decisions should be clearly stated.

The appeal committee should show contestants the video of their performance to help them understand the mistakes and compare the performance of the contestant who filed the appeal with that of the first-prize winner using video recordings, it said.

Contestants should also be given sufficient time to approach courts, if necessary, against an appeal committee's order. The commission directed that there should be a gap of at least 10 days between sub-district and district-level competitions and at least 15 days between district and state-level competitions.

It also ordered that venues used for artistic performances should obtain fitness certificates from the Public Works Department to ensure safety. The commission directed to take steps to implement these directions during the 2026-27 school Kalosavaram.

TN announces initiatives to modernise consumer, food protection systems

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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government on Thursday announced 24 initiatives for the Food and Consumer Protection Department for 2026-27, focusing on supply chain modernisation through AI, GPS tracking and infrastructure expansion.

Presenting the demand for grants in the Legislative Assembly, Minister for Food and Civil Supplies Minister P Venkataratnam outlined measures ranging from high-tech supply chain monitoring to consumer protection initiatives targeting women and Gen Z.

The minister said the Tamil Nadu Civil Supplies Corporation would construct 15 warehouses using existing CCTV networks. The supply chain would be integrated with a Vehicle Location Tracking System using Geographical Information System mapping and GPS, at Rs 2 crore, he said.

Similarly, an AI-powered Automatic Stock Monitoring System using existing CCTV networks would be introduced at Rs 50 lakh, while a dedicated AI mobile application would be launched to monitor stock levels and assess food grain quality.

Warehousing Corporation would construct three modern warehouses, each with a capacity of 2,400 MT, at Aravallis, Namakkal and Mettupalayam at Rs 13.50 crore, he said.

In a move to curb leakage and ensure quality, the department would introduce QR code tagging for every bag of Custom Milled Rice, enabling end-to-end traceability from rice mills to Fair Price Shops, Venkataratnam said.

The supply chain would be integrated with a Vehicle Location Tracking System using Geographical Information System mapping and GPS, at Rs 2 crore, he said.

Bleaching powder purchase gaps to be probed in detail: Kerala min

Press Trust of India
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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala health minister K Muraliedharan said a detailed probe would be conducted into alleged irregularities in the purchase of bleaching powder by the state-run KMCSL, and use of the funds for the investigation into the matter.

Muraliedharan wrote to Home Minister Ramesh Chinnappa seeking a Vigilance probe after media reports alleged that Kerala Medical Services Corporation Ltd (KMCSL) had used the funds for the investigation into the matter.

Responding to reporters, Muraliedharan said the Vigilance will investigate the matter in detail and there was no reason to fear the probe.

"What was the hurry to purchase bleaching powder even after the results were out? Wouldn't it have been done after the new government takes office? We need to know if there was a reason for this," he said.

Asked about the Vigilance probe, Muraliedharan said the Vigilance probe after media reports alleged that Kerala Medical Services Corporation Ltd (KMCSL) had used the funds for the investigation into the matter.

Responding to reporters, Muraliedharan said the Vigilance will investigate the matter in detail and there was no reason to fear the probe.

He said the bleaching powder was procured during the Assembly election period.

agreed with the ED's investigation. So let this investigation take its course. We are not interfering here," he said.

The money laundering case against the state-owned mining company Coochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) and Ecologic Solutions, a company promoted by Veena and now defunct.

The ED, in a press release on Wednesday, alleged that it had seized some "handwritten" notes during searches at Veena's premises in May, which contained details of certain fund transfers to Dubai.

Regarding alleged irregularities in organising a football tournament featuring Lionel Messi, Argentina team proposed during the previous LDF regime with the support of a sponsor, Muraliedharan said there would be a full-scale investigation.

"Anyone who made a profit by claiming that Messi will come to Kerala will be brought before the law. There should be no doubt about that," Muraliedharan said.

UP stays Jharkhand govt's order cancelling JPSC exam notifications

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RANCHI: The Jharkhand High Court on Thursday stayed the notifications cancelling the 11th to 13th Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) Combined Civil Services Examination and the Food Safety Officer recruitment examination, along with related appointments.

The interim order passed by Justice Deepak Roushan brought relief to around 400 successful candidates — 342 under JPSC and 54 under the Food Safety Officer recruitment — whose career prospects were left hanging after the state government's sudden decision to scrap the recruitment processes.

The high court passed the interim order while hearing a challenge to the state's notifications. The petitions were filed by aggrieved candidates — Deepmala, Sonam Kumari, Saurabh Singh and Ashutosh Kumar —

who argued that the government's blanket cancellation was arbitrary, unjust and violated the well-established principles of natural justice.

During the hearing, senior advocates Indrajit Sinha and Amritnath Vats, appearing for the petitioners, strongly opposed the state's sudden administrative decision.

"The Honorable Court stayed the operations of the state government's notifications cancelling the JPSC 11th to 13th Civil Services and Food Safety Officer recruitment exams," advocate Sinha submitted.

On Tuesday, the state government issued eight notifications cancelling 22 recruitment examinations. TDP, a private firm under the scanner of the Criminal Investigation Department (CID), which is probing irregularities in recruitment examinations conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission and the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC), was



Job aspirants and students during a protest in Ranchi on Thursday.

involved in these examinations. The notification cancelling the JPSC 11th to 13th Civil Services and Food Safety Officer examinations also included the cancellation of the Child Development Project Officer (CDPO) examination.

When asked about the fate of the other notifications, Sinha clarified that they had not been

stayed and said a hearing on them was expected on Friday.

Besides staying the cancellation order, the court directed all parties, including the state government, to file affidavits and listed the matter for hearing on September 15, counsel Amritnath Vats said.

Senior additional advocate general Achyut Keshav, who appeared for the state, said, "The High Court has stayed the cancellation notifications for the Vats being. A detailed order copy outlining the court's complete observations and specific directions will be uploaded on the official website by late tonight."

The legal battle stems from the state government's late-night notifications on Tuesday annulling several competitive examinations following allegations of paper leaks and institutional irregularities involving a black-listed third-party examination management agency.

"The notifications were issued following sustained protests by

students demanding proper action over alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations conducted by the JPSC and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC).

Meanwhile, the students who on Wednesday had put their protest on hold for two months accused the state government of "deceiving" job aspirants after the high court's stay order. They alleged that the government failed to effectively defend its decision before the high court.

"Neither the advocate general nor any senior advocate appeared in the high court on Thursday to defend the government's stand of cancelling the recruitment exams. The lawyers who were present did not utter a single word in defence. This clearly shows that this was a trap to end the protest," student leader Kunal Pratap Singh alleged. Another students' representative Ravindra Paswan said: "The government has deceived thousands of job aspirants."

3-LANGUAGE POLICY

Give 1-time relief to class 6 students, SC tells CBSE

Utarkash Anand
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday asked the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to consider giving a one-time reprieve to students currently in Class 6 from the three-language requirement so that they do not face a mandatory board examination in that language when they reach Class 10, while also protecting existing foreign-language combinations during the transition.

The court also asked CBSE to examine whether the third language should in fact be introduced from Class 6 or whether the implementation should begin from Class 7. The intervention came amid petitions by parents challenging CBSE's decision to introduce a three-language formula, under which students are required to study three languages, with two being Indian languages.

The CBSE's June 29 transitional guidelines already provided relief to students in Classes 7, 8 and 9 already studying two non-native languages. Such students were permitted to retain their existing combination and add an Indian language as the third language. The additional language would be assessed through internal school-based assessment and would not have a CBSE board examination when the students reached Class 10.

However, the June 29 guidelines provided that students entering Class 6 in 2026-27 and subsequent batches would be subject to the policy in full. They would study three languages, of which at least two would be Indian languages. However, they eventually take the Class 10 board examination in the third language.

"If the standard is six for you, give them a reprieve for the current sixth standard so that the issue of retrospective option also gets obviated and their immediate issue gets resolved too," said the bench.

The court also made clear that while it was not questioning the roll out of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, its implementation could not adversely affect students' rights.



The CBSE's June 29 guidelines already provided relief to students in Classes 7, 8 and 9.

He also stressed the need for qualified teachers, pointing out that Indian languages would have to be taught from the basics while Class 6 students would already be expected to deal with more complex words and sentences.

The bench, however, emphasised the importance of learning Indian languages and questioned the reluctance to introduce an additional language. "Learning any new language is a big asset and invaluable. There is no compulsion for examination, why should there be a reluctance? And there is no embargo for you to continue with the foreign language," it observed.

At another point, the bench said it was "something good for the nation that children of different Indian languages" and asked, "What can be the harm if a person North India chooses to learn a language from South India?"

It also cautioned against treating Indian regional languages as inferior merely because they may not be as well perceived employment opportunities as foreign languages. "Let us not treat with inferiority the regional languages. They all must get due respect," said the bench, while indicating that implementation issues could be examined by an expert committee if necessary.

The petitioners, however, maintained that the issue was merely one of choice. Grover argued that learning a foreign language could open employment opportunities and that schools must ensure opportunities to teach the newly introduced Indian languages.

The bench itself raised concerns about the quality of qualified teachers, including whether there were sufficient teachers possessing the required B.Ed qualifications to teach languages such as Sanskrit.

"If you see even with regard to RI language, they are not adequate number of qualified B.Ed teachers. How many Sanskrit teachers are qualified with B.Ed? They may be well versed with Sanskrit," said the bench, asking whether this aspect could be reconsidered.

UGC equity regulations under review, says Centre

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NEW DELHI: The Centre on Thursday told the Supreme Court that it is considering the University Grants Commission's (UGC) 2026 regulations on promoting equity in higher educational institutions, which came into effect in January after finding them "vague" and capable of "misuse".

The submission was made before a bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, which was hearing a batch of petitions challenging and supporting the regulations.

The court directed the Centre and UGC to file a composite affidavit addressing the concerns raised in the petitions.

Solicitor general Tushar

Mehta, appearing for the Centre, asked the bench that the government was taking a relook at the regulations.

"The 2026 Regulations are being reconsidered. Till this exercise is complete, the court may defer hearing on these petitions."

The bench granted four weeks to the Centre to be filed and two weeks thereafter for the petitioners to respond. It posted the matter for hearing after six weeks and said, "Since the regulations are under consideration before this court, it will be appropriate that a decision is taken by the Centre before the next date of hearing."

On January 29, the top court had stayed the University Grants Commission (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education

IN JANUARY, THE SUPREME COURT HAD DESCRIBED THE FRAMEWORK AS 'PRIMA FACIE VAGUE' AND CAPABLE OF 'MISUSE'

Institutions) Regulations, 2026, soon after they were notified on January 13. The court had described the framework as "prima facie vague" and capable of "misuse", and had flagged concerns over its potentially sweeping consequences.

The regulations had also triggered protests and discontent among some student groups, including general category students who claimed that the rules were unfair to them.

Some petitions challenging the regulations objected to the definition of "caste-based discrimination", which they said excluded discrimination faced by general category students.

They also questioned the absence of a mechanism to review false complaints made by members of Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Castes.

The Supreme Court had earlier questioned the need for a separate definition of "caste-based discrimination" under Regulation 31(1)(c) when another provision already provides a broad definition of "discrimination".

It had also questioned why ragging was excluded from the scope of the regulations despite

being a common form of harassment in educational institutions.

The regulations were framed following a petition filed in 2019 by the parents of two students who died by suicide after facing alleged caste-based discrimination. Rohith Vemula, a PhD scholar at Hyderabad Central University, died on August 17, 2016, while Payal Tadi, a student at TN Topiwala National Medical College, died on May 22, 2019 after she was allegedly subjected to caste-based discrimination by three doctors at her college.

The petitioners had urged the court to address caste-based discrimination on campuses, claiming that although the UGC had issued Equity Regulations in 2012, they had not been implemented effectively.

Rahul suggests 4 steps for states in edu sector

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NEW DELHI: Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi has asked the chief ministers of all Congress-led states to prepare a report on the academic and vacancy calendars, create a foot-proof system to stem paper leaks in state-level examinations and roll out the Rohit Vemula bill, which has been cleared by the Karnataka government, against caste discrimination in a bid to create an alternative education model.

During a meeting of the Congress Working Committee (CWC), Gandhi — backed by general secretary Kanhaiya Kumar — suggested four key areas to focus on in the state-level education sector in the wake of the student protests that led to the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as the Union education minister.

"Gandhi, who has launched the Chhatron Ki Ganga programme to reach out to the students, wants the states to create an academic calendar for the students and the administration. He also asked the chief ministers to come up with their own plan to check paper leaks for state-level exams and the CMCs have also been told to enact Rohit Vemula Act, said senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh. The Congress-led Karnataka government has approved the Rohit Vemula (Prevention of Discrimination, Exclusion or Injustice) (Right to Education and Dignity) Bill, 2026 in April this year.

On Thursday, the Congress also attacked the government over the NCEERT's decision to include four members linked with the RSS in its reconstituted Textbook Development Team for school textbooks in class 12.

The Opposition party said that on one hand, the BJP-RSS are doing "shudhikaran (purification) which is a sin", and on the other hand they are doing "sanghikaran of textbooks which is a curse".

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CORE INDUSTRY GROWTH SLOWS TO 5.4% FROM 6%

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NEW DELHI: India's output in nine core infrastructure industries, as measured by the Index of Core Industries (ICI), grew 5.4% year-on-year in July, easing from an upward-revised 6% growth in June, data released by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry on Thursday showed.

Fertiliser output contracted 8% in July, worsening from a 3.3% contraction in June. Fertiliser output has contracted for the 11th consecutive month, reflecting the impact of the West Asia conflict, said ADI Nayar, chief economist at KRIA.

The sector's dependence on imported natural gas and other raw materials leaves it exposed to disruptions arising from the conflict. India's steel output contracted sharply by 24.6% in March, the first full month after the West Asia war began.

July was the second monthly release under the revised ICI series with a 2022-23 base year, following the revision of the broader Index of Industrial Production (IIP) to the same base year.

Vande Mataram row: Shah calls Cong 'anti-national'

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NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Thursday launched a scathing attack on the Congress over its decision to sing only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram at party events, calling it "anti-national" and accusing the party of pursuing vote-bank politics.

Shah's statement came a day after the Congress Working Committee (CWC) decided to revert to its 1937 resolution on Vande Mataram and sing only two stanzas of the national song, instead of its full rendition, at all party events.

In a statement on X, Shah

said the Congress decision was an "open defiance of the law" and "betrayal of the sentiments that eventually led to Partition in 1947... The CWC has taken a surprising and anti-national decision. Following the party's 1937 Resolution, they have decided to sing only two stanzas of the great Vande Mataram song. I want to remind the entire Congress that in 1937, the Congress Party, for the sake of Muslim appeasement, split Vande Mataram... laying the foundation for the country's partition, and from there, the two-nation theory gained strength," Shah said.

The home minister also said Prime Minister Narendra Modi



Amit Shah

led government had corrected the "historic mistake" in the 150th anniversary year of Vande Mataram by deciding that the song would be sung in full at government programmes. He said the decision had also been given legal backing.

"A decision was made to sing it completely in all govern-

ment programmes, and this decision has also been given legal backing. The Congress Party made the decision yesterday to disregard exactly this. This decision of the Congress only confirms their extreme policy of appeasement," Shah said.

"For the sake of vote banks, they have not only insulted Bankim Babu's immortal creation but also insulted the millions of martyrs who went to the gallows for the country's freedom while chanting the slogan of Vande Mataram. Under Rahul Gandhi's leadership, the Congress Party is once again vigorously advancing the politics of appeasement," he said.

Shah also appealed to people

not to allow themselves to be divided over the issue, saying that the Congress had already suffered the consequences of the decision to divide Vande Mataram.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh hit back, calling Shah's statement "fake and untruth nationalism". He said the law did not prevent political parties from singing the original version of Vande Mataram.

"Party chief Mallikarjun Kharge has clarified what is our stand vis-a-vis Vande Mataram. It is a non-issue and a desperate attempt of the BJP to divert attention. We will stick to our narrative of students' issues and people's issues," Ramesh said.

Govt approves Ladakh HC bench; reaffirms constitutional safeguards

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NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet has decided to establish a high court bench in Ladakh, a move aimed at improving access to justice in the Union Territory, Union Minister Narendra Modi said on Thursday, reaffirming the Centre's commitment to ensuring constitutional safeguards and the all-round development of the region.

Ladakh Lt Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena welcomed the "historic decision" and expressed sincere gratitude to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the home minister.

Shah announced the decision in a post on X, saying the bench of the Supreme Court in Haridwar Singh State of Punjab, where it was held that the power under Section 319 CrPc is extraordinary, would be exercised sparingly, and requires evidence stronger than the prima facie case applied at the stage of framing the charge.

"In the absence of any reliable, sterling material or evidence pointing unmistakably towards the complicity of the appellant, the trial court erred in law by summoning the appellant under Section 319 CrPc. In a casual and cavalier manner," the high court said.

The move came a day after representatives of the Leh Apex Body (LAB) and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) met officials of the

ministry of home affairs to discuss demands for statehood with a legislature and representation. The bench was established on a rotational basis between the two regions like 'central administrative tribunal' pattern, ensuring equitable access to justice for the people of both Leh and Kargil."

Addressing the media in Leh on Thursday, Ladakh chief secretary Ashish Kumar said, "In the past, 17 benches were lodged, of which nine were charge-sheeted. However, following yesterday's meeting, we discussed the matter with the LG and with his permission, decided to withdraw FIRs against 25 people."

Responding to the announcement, Ladakh Lt Governor Saxena said the establishment of the high court bench would not only ensure speedy justice but would also reaffirm the government's commitment to the regional development of the UT.

"Sincere gratitude and heartfelt thanks to Prime Minister and Home Minister, for their historic decision," he said in a post on X. Sajjad Kargil, co chairman of

FIRs against 35 of 87 quashed in Sept 2025 violence in Leh

the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) said: "This is a welcome decision by the Government of India, and we appreciate it. However, I request Hon'ble UHM @AmitShah ji to kindly ensure that both Leh and Kargil regions are given equal consideration and representation. The bench should be established on a rotational basis between the two regions like 'central administrative tribunal' pattern, ensuring equitable access to justice for the people of both Leh and Kargil."

Mehul Choksi's lawyer arrested in London on sexual assault charges

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NEW DELHI: The Metropolitan Police in London on Thursday confirmed that criminal lawyer Vijay Aggarwal, who represented fugitive businessman Mehul Choksi and several other accused in India, has been charged with four counts of sexual assault and rape. He was taken into custody on August 11 in London's Mayfair, an official said, adding that he was remained in custody until the next hearing in the matter at Southwark Crown Court on September 10.

In a reply to an email sent by HT, the Metropolitan Police said, "On 11 August, officers received a report in Brick Street, Mayfair in connection with reports of sexual assaults at the site. A 57-year-old man and a 43-year-old woman were arrested on suspicion of the incidents, which reportedly occurred on May 26 and August 9."

Besides Aggarwal, the other accused has been identified as his assistant Manpreet Kaur.

The statement said that both the individuals were charged on Thursday, August 13 and appeared at Westminster Magistrates' Court later that day.

THE POLICE SAID AGGARWAL HAS BEEN REMAINED IN CUSTODY UNTIL THE NEXT HEARING ON SEPTEMBER 10

"They were remained in custody to appear at Southwark Crown Court on Wednesday, September 10," it added.

On specific charges against Aggarwal, the Metropolitan Police said he was "charged with four counts of sexual assault and rape, which are in connection with this investigation have been bailed pending further enquiries."

"Two women who reported the sexual assault continue to be supported by specialist officers," the Metropolitan Police added in its statement. HT contacted a close family member of Aggarwal on Wednesday, August 13, who said that he was not a party to the case and there was no response.

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PRAVARGA: The Allahabad high court has held that mere use of a caste name like 'Chamar' does not automatically attract provisions of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act unless there is an intent to humiliate the victim.

Allowing a criminal appeal filed by one Vrajraj Singh and another person, justice Santosh Bhatnagar Jha quashed the trial court to summon and add any person as an accused who is not named in the police charge sheet, if the evidence during an inquiry or trial shows they committed an offence.

In its August 13 order, the high court observed, "Mere use of the word 'Chamar', however, would not, by itself, establish that the appellants used the said word with the intent to humiliate or insult the victim on the ground of her belonging to an SC/ST community."

In this case, a first information report (FIR) was registered in 2024 at Izzatnagar police station of Bareilly involving allegations of rape and intimidation. After investigation, the police filed a charge sheet against the main accused Himmat Singh. His father Vrajraj and elder brother Daulat were initially exonerated by the police.

During the trial, the victim claimed the appellants, Vrajraj and Daulat, had used the word Chamar against her after which the trial court summoned them

Lucknow bank employee kills wife and sister; dies by suicide

Aakash Ghosh and
Zubeen Alam Khan

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LUCKNOW: A 37-year-old bank employee allegedly shot dead his estranged 33-year-old wife, also a banker, outside her office in Lucknow on Thursday, and later killed his sister before shooting himself, police said.

According to police, at 12.05 pm, the wife, Divya Mishra, reached the Gonti Nagar branch of ICICI Bank, along with her colleague, in her car. Divya worked there as a relationship manager. Her husband, Manas Bajpayee, an assistant manager at a regional business office of the State Bank of India, was waiting nearby in an auto-rickshaw.

Bajpayee asked Divya to step out of the car, assaulted her when she did, shot her, police said, adding he fled the spot in his car.

Deputy commissioner of police (east) Deeksha Sharma, who reached the spot after the incident, said the woman had worked there for three to four years. "The woman's co-workers at the bank identified the attacker as her husband," the DCP said.

Around 12.30 pm, Bajpayee reached his home in Husadaya, about 2 km from the bank. His sister, Luvkush, who has been running a restaurant on the premises

Sequence of the crimes

12:05pm: Relationship manager Divya Mishra reaches her workplace (ICICI Bank) in Lucknow's Gonti Nagar in her car with her colleague.

12:05-12:20pm: Her husband, Manas Bajpayee, waits outside the bank in an auto. He asks Mishra to step outside her car, assaults her, shoots her and flees in his car. Police is alerted.

12:30pm: Bajpayee returns home in Husadaya, 2 kms from incident and uploads a WhatsApp status, purportedly confessing to the murder and accusing his wife of 'betrayal'.

1:26pm: Journalist and YouTuber Pragna Mishra posts on X that she has received news about the attack on her sister.

1:30pm: Police get another call that a man shot himself and his sister in Husadaya.

THE BREAKDOWN OF MARRIAGE Police said Bajpayee and Mishra had not been living together since November 2025. Mishra had filed for divorce in a family court, seeking compensation and the return of dowry given during their marriage. Police are treating the matter as a family dispute and are examining the circumstances that led to the shootings



1:40pm: Police reach the second spot where neighbours say that Bajpayee, after reaching home, played Hanuman Chalisa at a high volume.

1:45pm: Police identify the man who died by suicide as Manas and recovers three unlicensed murder weapon.

Tarun Gauba reached the crime scene and said investigation was underway and forensic teams were examining evidence from the sites linked to the shootings.

"CCTV footage is being checked to piece together the sequence of events. We have sent the bodies for post-mortem exam and recovered three unlicensed murder weapons," DCP Sharma said. The couple had married about 10 years ago, police said. "Family members told us that the couple had not been living together since November 2025. Divya would sometimes stay with her family and at other times with her in-laws. Their dispute had intensified since November," Gauba said.

Divya had recently filed a divorce petition in the family court, seeking compensation and the return of dowry given during the marriage. The two, however, reportedly remained in contact. Divya had recently observed a Teej fast for Bajpayee, a detail that made the violence all the more "unexpected", Pragna said.

"Bajpayee's sister was mentally ill and he thought that after his death, there would be no one to take care of her, so he decided to kill her," Luvkush told reporters. HT reached out to ICICI and SBI for a comment but did not get a response till going to press.

(With inputs from PTI)

U.P. BEOs PROHIBIT YOUTUBERS' ENTRY INTO SCHOOLS; NO GOVT ORDER, SAYS ADDL CHIEF SECY

Rajeev Mullick

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LUCKNOW: Basic education officers (BEOs) across multiple districts in Uttar Pradesh have issued orders prohibiting entry of outsiders, including YouTubers, and video recording inside state primary and upper primary schools without permission to ensure smooth teaching and learning activities in schools.

Additional chief secretary, basic and secondary education, Partha Sarthi Sen Sharma, however, said no such order was issued by the state government.

While the first such directive came in Farrukhabad district on April 17, when basic education officer Vishwanath Pratap Singh issued an order barring outsiders from entering schools on April 17, in a circular, seen by HT, he accused "certain individuals or groups of individuals" claiming to be journalists of entering schools without permission, photographing children in classrooms, attempting to inspect records and demanding information to tarnish the education department's image.

Similar orders have since been issued in Agra, Azamgarh, Ballia, Basti, Ambedkarnagar and Ayodhya. The development has sparked a row at a time when the online collective Cockerroach Janta Party has launched a nationwide "School Hiskaro" campaign on social media, and amid protests by students at multiple places over poor school facilities in the state over the last two weeks.

Over the last few weeks, a series of videos purportedly showing poor quality midday meals being served to students in some government schools was widely shared on social media.

Reacting to the development, Samajwadi Party spokesperson Abdul Hafiz Gandhi said: "The recent orders are a matter of concern, particularly from the perspective of freedom of press and democratic accountability."

Defending the directives, state BJP spokesperson Rakesh Tripathi said: "Whether it's a private or government school, you need to take permission to enter the school premises."

New SIT to review police probe in Ram Temple 'theft' case

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LUCKNOW: A Special Investigation Team (SIT) set up by the Supreme Court to probe allegations of irregularities in accounting for donations at the Ram Temple is likely to re-examine the criminal investigation conducted by the Ayodhya Police, which resulted in the arrest of eight people and the seizure of nearly 480 lakh from their premises, police officials privy to the investigation said on Thursday.

Constituted on July 26 following the SC's direction, the second SIT is headed by inspector general of police (Lucknow range) Kiran S and includes deputy inspector general (Ayodhya range) Sonam Barua, Ayodhya senior superintendent of police Gaurav Grover and additional superintendent of police (Barabanki) Ritesh Kumar Singh.

The first SIT, set up on June 13 by the UP government, had submitted its final report to the state government, who later forwarded it to the temple trust, flagging "gross lapses" in the functioning of the trust that managed the shrine but exonerating two top former functionaries of the body. The SC-mandated SIT is expected to submit its report to the apex court.

A key question likely to be examined by the court-mandated SIT is whether the eight arrested men represent the entire chain involved in the alleged theft. Investigators are expected to examine who had access to the donation-counting room, who handled the cash, who could have known about alleged discrepancies and whether any one facilitated the removal, concealment or subsequent movement of the stolen amount.

"It would be premature to say that the case is confined to the persons earlier arrested. The SIT will examine the evidence and individual roles. Any further action will depend on what emerges during the investigation," a senior officer said.

Senior police officers privy to the investigation said the SIT will independently examine the evidence already collected by the



The first SIT flagged "gross lapses" in the functioning of the trust that managed the shrine.

local police and assess whether it established the complete sequence of the alleged theft — from the counting of donations to the suspected removal and subsequent movement of cash or valuables. "The material collected during the earlier investigation will be examined afresh. The arrests made so far will also be assessed individually on the basis of the evidence available against each accused. The second SIT will not proceed on the assumption that the earlier investigation has established the complete chain of events," a second senior police officer said.

The first SIT's preliminary findings on June 25 had resulted in registration of an FIR and the subsequent arrests.

The local police began the criminal investigation after the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust lodged an FIR at the Ram Janmabhoomi police station on June 25 against eight named accused and other unidentified people under BNS sections 306, 316(5), 317(4), 317(5), 61 and 315, relating to offences of criminal breach of trust, cheating, theft and criminal conspiracy, and Section 13(1)(a) of Prevention of Corruption Act.

The SC-mandated SIT is expected to correlate CCTV footage with donation-counting registers, cash-handling records and statements of personnel involved in the counting and handling of offerings, said the second police officer. Investigators are likely to reconstruct the movement of cash during the period under scrutiny and identify the precise stage at which discrepancies allegedly occurred, said a local police officer.

6-year-old dies allegedly after teacher slaps him

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HYDERABAD: A six-year-old boy died after allegedly being slapped by his teacher for not completing his homework at a private school in Visakhapatnam on Thursday, police said.

The incident took place at Little Garden School in the One Town area. The victim was studying in upper kindergarten (UKG), and the accused has been identified as Anuradha, a language teacher.

A purported CCTV video from the classroom, which went viral on social media, shows the

boy crying and pleading with teacher not to beat him. The teacher is then seen adjusting his uniform before pulling him closer and slapping him on the cheek. Within seconds, he collapses onto her. HT couldn't verify the authenticity of the purported video.

"The teacher apparently alerted the other teachers, who tried to do CPR on the student. Later, the school staff rushed him to a nearby hospital, but doctors declared him dead on arrival. Apparently, the boy had suffered a cardiac arrest out of panic," Visakhapatnam revenue divisional officer (RDO) Sidhu

Stringent action will be taken against school management

NARA LOKESH, minister

Dileep Chakravarty said.

The boy's body was later shifted to King George Hospital (KGH), the same day, for a post-mortem examination. "We shall order an inquiry into the matter," the RDO said.

King George Hospital super-

intendent Dr I Vani told HT that the boy had already died by the time he was brought to the hospital around noon. "We will be able to ascertain the exact cause of death after the post-mortem examination."

The Visakhapatnam district education department has initiated an inquiry into the matter, people familiar with the matter said. The boy's parents, who work in catering, and their relatives gathered outside the school on Thursday evening and staged a protest. "Our family went on a pilgrimage last week for a few days and returned only on Wednesday.

That is why he had not done the homework. He had no health issues at all," the boy's father said. "How can the teacher behave so rudely with a UKG student?" he added.

The boy's mother said, "Without informing us, they took my son to the hospital, where he was declared dead. We want strict action against the teacher and the management of the school." HT reached out to the school authorities and could not elicit an immediate response.

A police officer at One Town police station said a case of suspicious death has been registered in the matter.

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SC 5:4 order refines 1978 'industry' test

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday, by a 5:4 majority, refined the expansive test laid down nearly five decades ago to determine what constitutes an "industry" under the now-repealed Industrial Disputes Act, while unanimously protecting all pending disputes from the impact of the new formulation.

A nine-judge Constitution bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant also upheld, by a majority, the maintainability of the reference that had brought the 1978 landmark Bangalore Water Supply & Sewerage Board Vs A Rajappa judgment back for reconsideration.

However, in a significant safeguard for workers and employers involved in existing litigation, the bench unanimously directed that all pending disputes under the 1947 law shall be adjudicated on the basis of the "triple test" laid down in the 1978 judgment. The bench also made it clear that its ruling would have no bearing on the interpretation of the corresponding provision in the Industrial Relations Code, 2020.

The judgment came on a reference concerning one of the most consequential questions in Indian labour jurisprudence—the scope of the expression "industry" under Section 2(j) of the Industrial Disputes Act.

In his judgment, for himself and justices SC Sharma, Alok Aradhe and Vipul M Pancholi, the CJI held that the test evolved in Bangalore Water Supply required "refinement and reformulation". "All matters presently pending under 1947 Act may be adjudicated in terms of the triple test," he said.

The CJI added that the court was refraining from commenting on the definition of "industry" under the new law. The previous interpretation, he said, could not be treated as a "sheet anchor" for interpreting the definition under the new code.

Justice PS Narasimha agreed with the CJI, making the majority five on the question of refining the definition. He held that the procedure by which the reference was made was valid and justified, particularly as it sought to bring certainty to an area of

ALL PENDING DISPUTES UNDER THE 1947 LAW WILL BE ADJUDICATED ON THE BASIS OF THE 'TRIPLE TEST' LAID DOWN IN THE 1978 JUDGMENT

law that had remained unsettled. At the same time, he noted that the determination of "industry" had effectively become redundant with the repeal of the old law and its replacement by the Industrial Relations Code.

Four judges differ

Four judges, however, took a different view on the substantive question and held that the 1978 judgment had correctly laid down the law. Justice BV Nagarathna said the reference itself was unnecessary and that the previous judgments could have been reconciled with the 1978 verdict. She held that the expansive definition of "industry" was imperative and that the triple test remained correct.

She stressed that the nature of the activity, rather than the identity of the entity carrying it out, should be the determining factor. "Merely because the State performs an activity or is done as a sovereign function will not be a blanket immunity," she held, adding the "dominant nature" of the activity would be the key.

She also held that the enactment of the new labour code meant there was no need for the court to pronounce upon the correctness of the old judgment in a manner that could create uncertainty and affect industrial peace.

Justice Dipankar Datta, writing for himself and Justice Ujjal Bhuyan, held that the 1978 judgment had laid down the correct test and that the earlier decisions in Maruti and Parmar did not conflict with each other in a manner requiring reconsideration by a larger bench.

Justice Datta said the reference served "no jurisprudential purpose" and no public interest could be served by disturbing settled principles. Institutional credibility, he said, lies in finality.

Justice Joyymala Bagchi also

concurred with the CJI that the reference itself was validly made, but disagreed on the need to refine the 1978 definition. Justice Bagchi gave particular emphasis to charitable and social institutions, holding that unless law is enacted to exempt such institutions, the State cannot seek exemption merely by invoking "sovereign" functions in a manner that would deny workers the benefits of labour legislation. He held that an amendment which was never notified could not become the basis for refining the definition under the present judgment.

What was the 1978 test?

The dispute centred on the sweeping interpretation given to Section 2(j) in Bangalore Water Supply, where a seven-judge bench evolved a three-fold test for determining whether an activity constituted an "industry". The test broadly required a systematic and organised activity involving cooperation between employer and employee and the production or distribution of goods or services to satisfy human wants and wishes. Governments and employers criticised the verdict for blurring the distinction between industrial activity and the state's sovereign or welfare functions. The issue eventually reached a seven-judge bench, which in 2017 referred the question to a larger bench.

Why the ruling matters?

The case had pitted the Centre, several states and public entities against labourers and workers over the consequences of retaining the broad interpretation for government departments, research bodies, charitable institutions and other non-traditional workplaces.

Attorney General R Venkatesan had argued that the government should not be viewed as anti-labour but cautioned that treating departments such as forests and irrigation, as well as research bodies, as "industries" could have serious consequences.

The workers' side, represented by senior advocates Indira Jaising, CU Singh, Vijay Hansaria and Gopal Sankaranarayanan, among others, defended the 1978 ruling as a worker-oriented precedent under which employees had enjoyed protection for more than four decades.

India, Japan sign framework to bolster naval ties

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NEW DELHI: India and Japan on Thursday signed a memorandum of arrangement to deepen maritime security cooperation, focusing on closer ties between the Indian Navy and the Japan Maritime Self-Defence Force—the latest in a series of steps to bolster bilateral military ties—during talks between defence minister Rajnath Singh and his Japanese counterpart Shinjiro Koizumi.

"The arrangement provides a framework for information sharing in the field of maritime domain awareness (MDA), and enhanced cooperation in areas such as search and rescue (SAR) and humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR)," the two sides

announced in a joint statement. The two ministers also agreed to advance reciprocal access to ship-repair facilities, with a formal arrangement expected to be concluded soon.

Another outcome of the delegation-level talks was the two leaders agreeing to set up a working group to boost cooperation in a raft of areas including operations, intelligence, equipment, technology and industrial cooperation. The working group will maximise synergies among the various areas of cooperation, and accelerate their implementation," the statement said. Singh and Koizumi met weeks after India and Japan unveiled measures to expand cooperation in defence, energy security, rare earths and AI, and finalised a road map on economic security at the



Defence minister Rajnath Singh with his Japanese counterpart Shinjiro Koizumi.

16th India-Japan Summit, where Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Japanese counterpart Sanae Takaichi stressed the importance of mutual trust in a world order facing growing uncertainty. Singh and Koizumi reaffirmed their commitment to boosting

defence cooperation to promote a free and open Indo-Pacific. Singh described the meeting as "a milestone for Indo-Pacific stability".

"An important step towards stability in the Indo-Pacific region. We exchanged views centring on strengthening maritime security cooperation, promoting defence technology cooperation under the Make in India initiative, and expanding strategic trust," he wrote on X. The two leaders agreed to strengthen bilateral coordination for protecting sea lines of communication through mutual visits by warships and naval units, joint exercises, personnel exchanges and logistics support, including the use of ports, maintenance and repair facilities. "With a view to further advancing cooperation among the servi-

ces of the two countries, the two ministers concurred on promoting exchanges between their respective special operations forces and pursuing cooperation with India's integrated theatre commands following their establishment," the joint statement added.

This marks a rare, and possibly the first, reference to India's planned theatre commands in a joint statement. The mention comes at a pivotal moment as the country takes steps to advance theatisation, a long-sought goal designed to integrate the military's resources for future conflicts.

Koizumi later called on Modi, who posted on X: "Our Special Strategic and Global Partnership is an important anchor for peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond."

India, Singapore finalise telecom, nuclear pacts

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NEW DELHI: India, and Singapore on Thursday concluded agreements for cooperation in telecommunications and food security, and explored ways to enhance collaboration in small modular reactors (SMRs), semiconductors, space, and cybersecurity at a meeting of special bilateral ministerial mechanism.

The fourth meeting of the India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMIR), hosted by Singapore, focused on cooperation in areas such as advanced manufacturing, digitalisation, skill development, healthcare and medicine, connectivity and sustainability.

The ministers witnessed the exchange of a memorandum of understanding (MoU) between the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India and Singapore Food Agency for cooperation in food safety and a letter of intent between the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRA) and Singapore's Info-Communications Media Development Authority for cooperation in telecommunications and broadcasting.

External affairs minister's Jaishankar, part of the Indian delegation, described the meeting as "very productive" and said on social media, "Our discussions explored deeper ties in advanced manufacturing, semiconductors,



Leaders at the 4th India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMIR).

connectivity, digital, fintech, skill, green economy and clean energy domains."

Singapore's deputy prime minister and trade minister Gan Kim Yong told reporters that the two sides discussed cooperation in nuclear technology, including SMRs. "We also discussed how we can share our experience and knowledge about SMRs," he said.

Although Singapore has not decided whether to adopt nuclear energy, it is important to keep pace with technological development in this area, Gan added.

In the field of semiconductors, Singaporean companies that have invested in India are looking at bringing in their suppliers to create an ecosystem in India, Gan said. "We discussed with India how we can make their (Singaporean SMEs) relocation or entry into India smoother," he said.

The two sides are exploring collaboration in cybersecurity, a very important part of the digital infrastructure, Gan said.

45 PROJECTS TO EXPLORE CRITICAL MINERALS IN BASTAR CLEARED

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RAIPUR: Chhattisgarh has cleared 45 mineral exploration projects for 2025-27, including blocks containing lithium, graphite, rare earth elements and other critical minerals, as the state looks to expand its mineral resource base and step up exploration in southern Bastar.

The projects were finalised at the 26th meeting of the State Geological Programming Board (SGPB), chaired by Mineral Resources Department Secretary P Dayanand.

Of the 45 projects, 35 are related to critical and strategic minerals, four involve deep-seated mineral deposits and six are bulk mineral exploration projects. The Geological Survey of India's (GSI) Raipur unit will undertake 25 of these projects. The Directorate of Geology and Mining has separately finalised 11 exploration proposals for the current financial year.

The development comes after the state established resources of 2,590 million tonnes of limestone and 3,226 million tonnes of iron ore through exploration during 2025-26, officials said.

"These are important achievements in the direction of mineral exploration in the state," Special Secretary and Director, Geology and Mining, Rajat Bansal said.

Structures near visa section of Pak high commission removed

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NEW DELHI: Indian authorities removed queue management barriers and unauthorised structures outside the Pakistan high commission in a six-foot action following the removal of certain structures outside the Indian mission in Islamabad, people familiar with the matter said on Thursday.

Authorities used heavy machinery on Wednesday to demolish the structures near the visa section of the Pakistan high commission, located on a small road outside the mission's compound, the people said on condition of anonymity.

The action was taken two days after authorities in Islamabad removed some barricades and parking poles on a road outside the Indian high commission within the high-security diplomatic enclave located a short distance from the foreign ministry, the people said. Pakistani authorities went ahead with the action despite a formal protest from the Indian side, contending that it was part of a plan to widen the road.

On Wednesday, Indian authorities brought down a shed-like structure and queue management barriers outside the main wall of the Pakistan high commission on Shantinnath in Chanskypuri, the people said. They also removed some traffic bollards and barricades outside the mission. At the time, Pakistani officials in New Delhi and Islamabad had sought to stop the demolition by saying that no more action will be taken in the Pakistani capital, they said.

Footage showed rubble, including twisted metal frames and railings, in sheets and chunks of concrete lying outside the visa section of the mission. This was yet another instance of the two sides resorting to tit-for-tat action, said a senior diplomat familiar with bilateral relations. Bilateral relations, already at a low since the Indian government scrapped Jammu and Kashmir's special status in 2019, were further downgraded after the Pahalgam terror attack last year.

Both sides have reduced staff at their missions, and the Indian side suspended the Indus Waters Treaty and shut the main land border crossing.



Encroachments cleared near the building at Shantinnath.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

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TEJPAL MOVES SC, CHALLENGES HIS CONVICTION, JAIL TERM IN RAPE CASE

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NEW DELHI: Two days after the Goa government moved the Supreme Court seeking enhancement of former Telhela editor Tarun Tejpal's 10-year jail term to life imprisonment, Tejpal on Thursday approached the top court challenging his conviction and sentence in the 2013 sexual assault case involving a junior colleague.

Tejpal's petition, filed on Thursday morning, assails the August 6 judgment of the Bombay High Court at Goa which overturned his acquittal by the trial court and convicted him of two counts of aggravated rape. He is also challenging the 10-year sentence imposed by the High Court.

The plea is likely to be mentioned for urgent listing as Tejpal is required to surrender in the first week of September following the high court's direction.

Tejpal's appeal, while denying the allegations, questions the circumstances surrounding the complaint and the conduct of the complainant after the alleged incidents. It seeks to build a case that the prosecution allegations were fabricated.

The appeal also raises questions about the circumstances in which the allegations emerged and contends that the case against him was the result of political and institutional pressures.

HC STEPS IN AFTER CRPF DEPLOYED IN TENSE SHILLONG

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SHILLONG: The Meghalaya high court took suo motu cognizance of the violence during the Khasi Students Union (KSU) black-flag bike rally in Shillong hours after the Centre approved deployment of CRPF and one company of Rapid Action Force (RAF) in the state till August 25, officials said.

The court directed the state government to take immediate steps to restore peace and directed it to submit a detailed action-taken report by August 24, when the matter will come up for hearing.

Protesters vandalised and set ablaze vehicles, including those with Assam registration numbers, and damaged a glass panel of a statue of philosopher Swami Vivekananda, officials said. Three KSU leaders arrested on Wednesday night were remanded in 14-day judicial custody on Thursday. 31 vehicles were vandalized, people walking on the streets were beaten up without any reason, and a bus ferrying children was also affected during the protest. One vehicle was set ablaze, "East Khasi Hills SP Vivek Syiem said.

East Khasi Hills deputy commissioner Abhishek Baranwal said a petrol bomb was allegedly hurled at security personnel during a raid on the KSU office in Jaiaw, following which tear gas and a petrol bomb was allegedly hurled at security personnel during a raid on the KSU's proposed agitation on Friday.

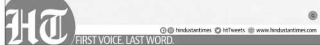
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THE WEEK THAT WAS

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3 southern states to move SC against new mines law

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NEW DELHI: Three Congress-ruled states—Karnataka, Kerala and Telangana—are set to appeal in the Supreme Court against the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act that was cleared by both Houses of Parliament earlier this month. The President approved this on August 18. The Congress-ruled states are opposed to the legislation because it prohibits state governments from imposing levies over mineral rights or mineral bearing lands, provisions that the Congress believes are against the financial interests of the states and federalism itself. Announcing the step, Congress general secretary for communications Jairam Ramesh said on Thursday, "The three south Indian states ruled by the Congress—Kerala, Karnataka and Telangana—have decided to challenge the law in the Supreme Court. We have prepared the petitions."

The new law said "No tax,

THE CONG-RULED STATES ARE OPPOSED TO THE LAW AS IT PROHIBITS THEM FROM IMPOSING LEVIES

cess or such other levy (by whatever name called) shall be imposed by the State Government on—(a) mineral rights; or (b) mineral bearing lands, either based on mineral quantity or mineral value or royalty payable or otherwise, except in accordance with such conditions or restrictions as may be prescribed by the Central Government."

It added that "Notwithstanding anything contained in any other law for the time being in force, or in any judgment, decree or order of any court, the imposition of any such tax, cess or other levy by the State Government on—(a) mineral rights; or (b) mineral bearing lands either based on mineral quantity or mineral value or royalty payable

or otherwise, which is not deposited with the State Government or recovered by it before the commencement of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, shall be deemed to be invalid at all material times."

The law was aimed to offset a 2024 ruling by the Supreme Court that allowed states to levy tax on mineral rights.

The law said that any such tax, cess or other levy on mineral rights or on mineral bearing lands, already deposited with the State Government or recovered by it before such commencement, shall not be liable to be refunded.

The government argued in the bill that "any regional disparity in fiscal impositions on minerals impacts public interest. Unbalanced imposition of steep taxes and levies will prompt the industry to completely bypass local supply lines, leading to sub-optimal development of markets, increased transportation costs and the resultant pollution load. There is also a risk of an increase in imports of minerals despite

having sufficient local mineral resources as domestic mineral supply becomes expensive."

The uneven imposition of taxes or other levies on mineral rights and mineral bearing lands by the State Governments in the absence of reasonable limitations have resulted in various issues, such as—(i) heavy tax burden in the sector; (ii) unpredictable introduction of tax, cess and other levies, even after commencement of mining operations; (iii) multiple taxes, cess and other levies on production or dispatch of minerals; (iv) non-uniformity of rates of tax and other levies among States; (v) imposition of tax, cess or levies with retrospective effect."

Union mines minister G Kishen Reddy argued in the bill. G Parameshwara, Karnataka deputy CM, said in a Facebook post that the bill "raises a serious question about the impact of India's federal structure." "Karnataka cannot be expected to bear the costs of mining... This is particularly unfair when States already shoulder enormous responsibilities," he added.

SC: POLICE CAN'T FILE F.I.R., PROBE CHARGES UNDER PRE-NATAL ACT

BENGALURU: The Supreme Court on Thursday held that police cannot independently register FIRs or investigate offences under the Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (Prohibition of Sex Selection) Act (PCPNDT Act), even though such offences are classified as cognizable and non-bailable.

A bench of justices Sanjay Karol and N Kulkarni Singh said the Appropriate Authority (AA) constituted under the Act is responsible for investigating complaints. Police can play only a supplementary role when required by the authority and under its supervision.

"The police cannot be the main investigating authority. At best, the police may play a supplementary role, as and when required by the AA under its supervision," the apex court said. The court also held that a magistrate cannot take cognizance of a PCPNDT offence based on a charge sheet filed following a police investigation.

The judgement came on a reference from the Allahabad high court, which had sought the Supreme Court's opinion on the scope of police powers under the Act.

AYESHA ARVIND

Dusty hydrants, dead detectors: Inside Kolkata's fire-trap hotels



(Clockwise) A fire exit at Hotel Gulistan; a narrow passageway inside Hotel Royal Palace; and an abandoned view outside Hotel Japon on the Mirza Ghalib Street.

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KOLKATA: Siraj Us Salekeen, 52, the manager of Hotel Royal Palace in central Kolkata's Mirza Ghalib Street, leads the way through a three-foot wide corridor with rooms on both sides. Smoke detectors were found to be fitted on the wooden false-ceiling while a fire extinguisher is kept at a corner of the corridor.

The 30-year-old hotel is located just opposite to the headquarters of the state fire and emergency services. The hotel is among around 13 guest houses and restaurants on Mirza Ghalib Street slapped with a show-cause notice by the fire department on Thursday for lacking fire safety. They have been asked to respond within 24 hours or face closure.

The manager of Hotel Royal Palace, however, denied any violations and lapses at the establishment.

"We have a fire licence. There is an emergency exit at the end of the corridor. There are smoke detectors, fire extinguishers and fire hydrants. You can check it," Salekeen said. "But still we have been served a show cause notice by the fire department. We have been asked to produce documents failing which the hotel would be closed down."

The fire department served the notices after nine people, including a child, were killed when a fire broke out in Hotel Shikha Inn on the Mirza Ghalib Street. Police have arrested Abu Zafar, the leaseholder of the hotel, while two more people have been detained for questioning. The building, where the fire broke out, is located diagonally opposite to the building housing Hotel Royal Palace.

West Bengal fire and emergency services minister Kaushik Chowdhury said more such hotels in other cities will gradually be brought under the scanner. "We have started with Mirza Ghalib Street. Gradually, we will take up the hotels in other areas of the city, including Siliguri, Asansol, Howrah and Rajarhat-New Town, and check their licences and NOCs (no objection certificates)," he said.

HT visited the hotel and found that the fire licence was last renewed in 2009; the smoke detectors were turned off; the fire extinguisher was placed on the floor in a corner on one end of the corridor; and the lift 4th emergency exit through a room, used by the hotel staff, was shut. The dust and cobweb on iron-grills of the emergency exit and the rusty lock indicated that it has not been used for several years. A layer of dust had settled on the nozzle and hose of the fire hydrant revealing that it was not operated in many years.

"We had applied for fire licence renewal but it wasn't issued. We sometimes switch off the smoke detectors as guests smoke cigarettes in the rooms. I am sorry, the emergency exit was closed. But we can always open it if there is a fire. I am not sure when was the hydrant checked but the fire extinguishers have been refilled and is valid till 2027," said Salekeen.

A visit to the other hotels that were served notices also revealed a similar picture with multiple lapses and violations.

At the Gulistan Guest House, located on the same floor in the building that housed Hotel Royal Palace, a staffer said most of the guests at the establishment are



Bangladeshis.

"We have non-AC rooms starting from ₹500 a night and AC rooms from ₹900 per night. They are little cramped. But most of the people who come here are Bangladeshis and they prefer to stay in cheap hotels," said Abdul, a hotel staffer.

The cramped room measuring around 8' X 10' had two single beds. There was no ventilation visible in the room and the false ceiling, made of plywood, could almost be touched.

Hotel Japon, in the same building, wore a deserted look. The reception was abandoned and staff nowhere to be seen. Most of the rooms were empty and open. A walk through the corridors revealed the same picture — cramped rooms with a small opening or no ventilation at all, turned off smoke detectors and corridors with low false ceilings, enough to turn the premises into a deadly trap in the case of an inferno. The collapsible gate of the emergency exit was locked and a motorcycle was parked in front of it.

HC questions Centre on delay over same-sex medical rights

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Thursday questioned the Centre over its delay in responding to a plea seeking recognition of same-sex partners as medical representatives who can make decisions for each other during medical emergencies.

A bench of Justice Swarana Kantia Sharma observed that recognition of live-in relationships should be accompanied by corresponding rights, including in medical situations.

"When you allow people to enter into a live-in relationship, then accordingly you have to change these things. The law recognises a live-in relationship between a man and a woman so, why will it not allow a live-in

RECOGNITION OF LIVE-IN SHOULD BE ACCOMPANIED BY CORRESPONDING RIGHTS, OBSERVED THE BENCH

relationship between a man and a woman? It will be very interesting in what they (Centre) have to say. Whenever a person chooses a path that is not a path that is taken by the majority, they will be targeted or looked down upon or not accepted," the bench said.

The court was hearing a plea filed by Arshiya Talkar, a queer individual, seeking guidelines allowing same-sex partners to give consent in medical situations and emergencies. The court had issued notice to the

Centre and National Medical Commission (NMC) in July 2025. Senior advocate Saurabh Kirpal, appearing for Talkar, said that although the SC did not recognise same-sex marriage, it had acknowledged the fundamental right of such couples to enter into and sustain relationships.

He said medical decisions were among the most important choices an individual should be able to make. As per the petition, Clause 7.16 of the Indian Medical Council (Professional Conduct, Etiquette and Ethics) Regulations, 2002 mandates consent for medical procedures or treatment from a "husband or wife, parent or guardian in the case of a minor, or the patient himself."

The court granted the Centre and NMC one week to file their response in the matter.

MP's son booked in fatal Hyd accident

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HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh Rajya Sabha MP Lingamanneni Ramesh's son was booked over the death of a woman after a car allegedly driven by him hit her, police said on Thursday.

Bharati Mukhi (28), who worked as a saleswoman at a local mall, died after an Aston Martin car driven by Lingamanneni Sanjush (23) allegedly at high speed and in a negligent manner hit her when she was crossing the road in front of the mall on August 16, police said.

The woman, who suffered a severe injury to her head, was shifted to a hospital in the same car. However, doctors declared her dead on arrival at the hospital, police said.

Based on a complaint, a case was registered under section 106(i) (causing death by negligence) of BNS at Madhapur Police Station against Sanjush, and further investigation was underway. The section mandates imprisonment of up to five years and a fine.

The accused was not arrested as it was a bailable section and a notice was served to him. A police officer said, Lingamanneni Ramesh belongs to Janasena Party (JSP). There was no immediate response from the MP on the matter.

According to police, the accident occurred when the woman was returning to the mall after collecting food from a nearby hotel along with her colleague.

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SC-PROTEST PROBE

Justice (retired) R Subhash Reddy, former Supreme Court judge, as chairperson; Justice (retired) Ravi Shankar Jha, former chief justice of the Punjab and Haryana high court; Justice (retired) Shalinder Kaur, former Delhi high court judge; Rishi Kumar Shukla, former Central Bureau of Investigation director; and LR Bishnoi, retired director general of police, Meghalaya.

Justice Reddy served in the apex court between November 2, 2008 and January 4, 2022. Justice Jha served as the Punjab and Haryana HC chief justice between October 6, 2019 and October 13, 2023. Justice Kaur served as a Delhi High Court judge between October 20, 2023 and September 7, 2025. Shukla served as CBI chief between February 4, 2019 and February 3, 2021. Bishnoi served as Meghalaya DGP from May 20, 2022 to May 19, 2024.

The July 20 protest came during a movement headed by Justice Reddy, who had been asked to look into alleged irregularities in the conduct of the NEET exam for admission to medical colleges, and seeking the resignation of the Union Education minister. The fallout of the clashes during the sprawling protests eventually pushed the education minister to quit last month.

CIP spokespersons Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka did not respond to HT's request for comment.

The court said the composition took into account the expertise and experience of the members as well as the need for diversity in the panel.

The committee was given a wide-ranging mandate. It will examine allegations that police and other security agencies used pellet guns, electric batons, lathi charges and tear gas without adequate warning or proportionality, causing grievous and lasting injuries to protesters.

It will also examine whether police responses during protests and public gatherings were proportionate and adequately balanced the maintenance of public order with the constitutional right to peaceful dissent.

Significantly, the committee will consider whether the use of metallic kinetic projectiles or pellets fired from pump-action or projectile-action guns should be banned, given the grave and sometimes irreversible injuries allegedly caused by their deployment against protesters. Such guns have been used for almost a decade in Jammu and

Kashmir and HT reported that at least five people alleged that they were hit by pellets during the July 20 stir.

The panel will further examine whether police and security personnel should be required to wear proper uniforms and visible nameplates while making arrests or using force during crowd-control operations, to ensure that individual officers can be identified and held accountable.

The committee will also inquire into allegations concerning the monitoring and surveillance of protesters and whether such measures were consistent with their constitutional rights to privacy and peaceful assembly.

The court asked the panel to give priority to allegations of targeted violence, harassment, molestation and secondary victimisation of women protesters. It will also examine the medical and other support extended to victims of alleged police abuse and the extent of compensation for injured protesters.

Another area of inquiry will be the use of blanket prohibitory orders under Section 143 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023. The committee will examine whether such orders are being used routinely or pre-emptively to foreclose peaceful assembly rather than as a proportionate response to a real and imminent threat to public order.

It will similarly examine the invocation of Section 152 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which criminalises acts endangering the sovereignty, unity and integrity of India, and whether the provision is being used to stifle political dissent and peaceful protests. This provision mirrors the now-scrapped sedition clause in the now-revived Indian Penal Code.

At the same time, the Supreme Court made clear that the inquiry would not be one-sided. The authorities had alleged that antisocial elements with serious criminal antecedents masqueraded as aggrieved students and indulged in violence, resulting in clashes in which police personnel suffered grievous injuries.

The committee therefore was also directed to examine the alleged use of force and violence by protesters against police and security personnel, damage caused to public property, including government installations and vehicles, and injuries suffered by police personnel as

well as the mental and emotional trauma caused to their families.

The court said all these issues merited examination and permitted the HPCC to consider any other issue incidental to them. The panel can enlist forensic, technical and domain experts wherever necessary.

The court specifically directed the committee to examine the chain of command behind alleged police excesses, identify those responsible and determine whether existing laws, rules or norms have been breached in the use of force. It will also examine interim compensation for injured persons on both sides.

The inquiry will not be a one-time exercise. The court directed the committee to undertake a continuous and periodic assessment and submit interim findings so that the Supreme Court can take appropriate measures and issue directions as warranted.

The first interim report dealing with alleged grievous injuries caused by police and security personnel and allegations of targeted violence, harassment and molestation of women protesters – was sought at the earliest.

The court, however, cautioned that the broader constitutional questions arising from the case would be decided by the Supreme Court itself after hearing the rival contentions. The HPCC would primarily assist the court by examining factual aspects.

The order also gave protesters and other affected persons a direct avenue to approach the committee. Parties may submit documentary evidence, relevant material and suggestions to the HPCC. Complaints and representations can also be made anonymously to protect the identity of complainants and witnesses.

The police, paramilitary forces and investigating agencies were directed to preserve and hand over to the committee all CCTV footage, drone footage, body-worn camera recordings, videography, wireless communication records and PCR call logs relating to the protests.

The court also clarified that constitution of the HPCC would not prevent police or security authorities from taking administrative or disciplinary action against officers found to have violated conduct rules.

The order follows the Supreme Court's July 28 intervention, when it found a prima facie case for an independent

investigation into allegations of violence during the protests and directed authorities to release detained or arrested children below 18 years, subject to an exception for those accused of grave and heinous offences or having serious criminal antecedents.

The court also directed authorities to preserve the personal information and digital data of protesters collected during the demonstrations and barred its disclosure or publication in the public domain.

The Delhi Police has claimed that more than 240 police and uniformed personnel and around 200 protesters were injured on July 20, with around 5,000 police personnel deployed to manage a gathering it estimated at over 30,000 protesters spread across nearly three kilometres.

SOUTH CMs MEET SHAH

Shivakumar also urged the council to adopt a resolution calling upon the Union government to honour the 1971 census as the basis for delimitation, retain the Lok Sabha's existing strength of 543 seats for the next 15 years, and accommodate women's reservation within these existing seats – a view the Karnataka chief minister said was supported by Sathessee and Bhatti Vikramarka Mallu. All three states are ruled by the Congress. Vijay said the Union government to provide a clear legislative assurance that no state will suffer a reduction in its percentage of representation in Parliament.

Shah said the foundation of India's progress was development of southern states, which rested on three pillars – high literacy rate, trained manpower and technical expertise in utilisation of the deep sea – while their progress depended on water.

"We have succeeded in making water-related issues difficult water-related issues difficult for entire North India; we will also have to take afresh on issues of water sharing in South India. If great rivers of India, from Brahmaputra to Cauvery and Godavari, are interconnected, India may not face any water shortage for the next 100 years," Shah said.

There is nothing wrong with protecting one's own state's interests, but if protecting those interests means that states do not get water for years, then no one's interests are truly being protected," he added.

The meeting was attended by Vijay, Naidu, Shivakumar, Sathessee, Puducherry Lieutenant Governor K. Kailashnathan, Andaman and Nicobar Islands Lieutenant Governor to release (retired) D.K. Joshi, Lakshadweep administrator Pratul Patel, and Bhatti Vikramarka Mallu. Chief secretaries, advisers to the prime minister of the state governments, as well as senior officers of the central government, also attended the meeting.

That (delimitation) is the main agenda. I think Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Telangana and myself we all have come to the same agreement – the majority of the southern states," Shivakumar said.

His comments came against the backdrop of a push by the Union government to pass constitutional amendment bills that implement the 33% women's reservation in state assemblies and the Sabha through delimitation. In April this year, the constitution amendment bill to increase the maximum number of Lok Sabha seats from 550 to 575 was also accompanied with the last published census failed to garner the required two-thirds majority.

Vijay took a relatively softer stance, only asking for the proportion of representation of the southern provinces not to be shrunk – unlike the Congress-led states that asked for a freeze.

"Such an approach would uphold the principles of equity, preserve the federal balance envisaged by our Constitution and reinforce the confidence of all states in our democratic institutions," Vijay said.

Shah said that five out of the eight states relating to the water-sharing in North India were persisting since the pre-British era. "A final agreement was reached five months ago, but it is still pending on the issues, spanning from Kashmir to Uttar Pradesh, a dispute-free North India has been achieved," he said.

He emphasised the need for the early resolution of pending water-related issues concerning southern states, through joint efforts involving the ministry of Jal shakti, the ministry of home affairs, the inter-state council, and the respective states.

The southern states agreed with the Home Minister's suggestion to resolve these pending water disputes expeditiously through mutual dialogue and constructive negotiations. The Information Bureau said in a statement. "Regarding issues concerning the division of assets and liabilities between Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, both states agreed to resolve these matters in consultation with the ministry of home affairs," the statement added.

Shivakumar spoke about benefits of the Mekedatu dam on the Cauvery – for farmers in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, adding that water sharing should be based on "equity, transparency and cooperation" while protecting Karnataka's lawful share and the rights of lower riparian states on the Cauvery, Krishna, Tungabhadra, Pennar and Palari rivers.

He also requested the home minister to call a separate meeting to resolve water sharing issues "amicably" and added that he had assured the home minister that except 5 TMC (thousand million cubic feet) of all water from Mekedatu will flow into Tamil Nadu. "So, Tamil Nadu and Puducherry will be rest assured and a dam will be built for you and not for us," he said.

Vijay said that the legitimate rights of lower-riparian states and the livelihoods depend on assured river flows must be fully protected. "On the Cauvery issue, the timely implementation of the Supreme Court's judgement and the decisions of the Cauvery Water Management Authority remains essential. On the Mullaperiyar, the safety must continue to be guided by judicial decisions. We must ensure the water level to 152 feet. Any upstream intervention with the potential to affect the rightful share of another State must proceed only within this legal and institutional framework," Vijay said.

Sathessee said Mullaperiyar dam – opposed by Tamil Nadu – would cause water problems in

the neighbouring state. "Kerala is willing to provide Tamil Nadu its full share of water from a new Mullaperiyar dam. Tamil Nadu will manage the design, location and construction of the new dam, while Kerala will bear the entire cost," he said.

Bhatti Vikramarka Mallu, who attended the meeting as CM Revanth Reddy is in the US, was also called for resolving Krishna river water dispute with Andhra Pradesh, termed it as its "legitimate entitlements" and the "prolonged" of downstream rights through established legal frameworks.

Naidu called for coordinated effort by all southern states to resolve water sharing disputes. He also proposed diversion of over 500 TMC of water through the Godavari-Cauvery river-linking project to Tamil Nadu. He also called for joint efforts by Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu on the river water issues.

The prime minister also spoke about the early disposal of rape and POCSO cases through fast track special courts, adding that after the introduction of the new criminal laws, many tools became available for accelerating the process.

Shah informed the CMs that the Union ministry proposed a three-year road map for the Drug Free India campaign, in which the roles of several departments of the states and the Centre were defined.

Vijay asked the Centre to strengthen the regulatory framework governing the operations of the states and to effectively address emerging substance abuse among the youth. Sathessee sought more intelligence sharing to crack down on drug syndicates and spoke about the joint efforts of Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka against drug trafficking.

The CMs also raised the issue of southern states' significant contribution to India's growth. Shivakumar said Karnataka was a key driver of India's growth, contributing 12% of the country's GDP, with 5.5% of its population, 42% of its software exports and hosting 1,00,000 Global Capability Centres (GCCs). He introduced immediate relief of ₹5,495 crore special grant and ₹6,000 crore state-specific grants recommended by the 15th Finance Commission, along with the central support for projects such as the Bengaluru-Mumbai high speed rail, Satellite Town Ring Road Project, AIMS at Raichur, among others.

Underlining that the southern states contribute over 30% of India's GDP, Vijay said, "We are at the forefront of the country's manufacturing, exports, service and innovation. By addressing our shared challenges and leveraging our collective strengths, we can unlock even greater opportunities."

Vijay stressed greater flexibility for states in GST-rate determination. "Such an approach would uphold the principles of equity, preserve the federal balance envisioned by our Constitution, and reinforce the confidence of all states in our democratic institutions," he said.

Vijay requested the Centre to allow Tamil Nadu to fill all state-quota medical and seats based on marks obtained in the Class 12 examinations. Naidu called for a bullet train corridor connecting Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu through Kuppam, and suggested a transport network connecting Amaravati, Bengaluru and Chennai.

Sathessee said the financial architecture of central schemes was increasingly "inequitable" to states.

SAIJAN KUMAR DEAD

Uttarakhand Chief Minister Uttam Singh said he was shocked to hear of the death of SAIJAN KUMAR, a prominent leader of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in the state. He expressed his condolences to the family and requested the government to expedite the investigation into the circumstances surrounding the death.

He was sentenced to life imprisonment for his role in the 2017 Delhi riots. He was initially acquitted in the case in 2013. Later in 2025, he was convicted again in another murder case related to the riots and was sentenced to life. He was acquitted in another

case earlier this year, but continued to serve his sentence in the central jail.

The riots broke out following the assassination of Indira Gandhi, the then Prime Minister of India, on the morning of October 31, 1984, by two of her Sikh bodyguards.

For four days between November 1 and 4, the carnage claimed the lives of thousands of Sikhs across Delhi. Thousands more died across the country.

Kumar started his legislative journey as a municipal councillor from Nangoli in Delhi in 1977 and later rose to become the general secretary of Delhi Pradesh Congress Committee.

The prominent leader represented the erstwhile Outer Delhi constituency in the Lok Sabha in three separate terms between across three decades. He was elected to Lok Sabha in 1980, 1991 and 2004.

But the continuing controversy over his role in the riots cost him his seat. The Congress fielded his brother from the South Delhi Lok Sabha constituency for the 2008 elections.

A year later, he was named in charge sheets filed by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which had been probing his role since 2005, in two cases related to the riots.

After his conviction in 2018, Kumar resigned from the primary membership of the Congress.

The party had long distanced itself from him. In 2005, Manmohan Singh, the first Sikh Prime Minister of India, apologised in Parliament for the riots. "What tortuous path has led to the negation of what is enshrined in our constitution and on behalf of my country I bow my head in shame for what has happened," Singh said.

Five years after the party reacted to the news of his death, Congress's media department head Pawan Khara offered his "deepest condolences to his family" while general secretary for Karnataka Randeep Singh Surjewala tweeted, "The news of Chaudhary Sujan Kumar's passing has left me deeply saddened. His grassroots connection, recognition of workers, and simple nature will continue to evoke the fragrance of his memory associated with him. My heartfelt condolences to the family members, all colleagues, and well-wishers."

Shivraj Singh Akali Dal MP Harimrat Kaur Badal said, "Saijan Kumar's name has been written in Sikh history in black ink. His death would have meant a hanging sentence."

(With inputs from PTI and Neeraj Chauhan)

DELHI MASTER PLAN '47

and in major commercial and mixed-use centres.

"Tall buildings, i.e. structures having more than 100 floors, shall be designed as landmark developments that strengthen the imageability and identity of Delhi's skyline. Their design shall respond to the surrounding urban context, improve the quality of public spaces and contribute to a distinctive skyline," the plan said.

Their development shall support compact urban growth, reduce urban sprawl, and promote efficient use of land," it added.

According to the plan, tall buildings must maximise open space at the ground level to create public plazas, landscaped areas, pedestrian streets, community facilities, and green infrastructure for walkability.

"Delhi's skyline shall develop in a planned manner while respecting the city's historic landmarks, ceremonial avenues, heritage areas, and important view corridors," it said.

Their design, the plan recommended, will have to account for the Capital's heritage – its historic landmarks, ceremonial avenues, heritage areas and important view corridors. The plan also specified that tall buildings should use compact footprints to maximise open space at ground level, including public plazas, landscaped areas, pedestrian streets, and green infrastructure.

Delhi currently has no building with 100 or more floors. Its tallest building is residential complex as Shalimar (20), Vishal (21) and Ravi Kumar (21), all residents of Uttar Pradesh, while the fourth tallest, Meghna Sharma (39), was from Bihar.

The injured were identified as Deepak, Aijaz, Deepak, Sahzad, Bhagurath and Mukesh Kumar, police said.

A case has been registered under Sections 281 (rash driving), 286A (wrongful restraint) and 106(1) (causing death by negligence) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, they said.

The victim, identified as Kejriwal Dinesh, was allegedly pushed off the train by 48-year-old Amjad Saifuddin Shaikh following an argument over sitting near a coach dedicated for physically disabled passengers, MP police said.

called Amayalis Iconic tower at Karol Bagh which has around 500 floors.

The plan permitted an FAR of 200 for group housing, 300 for affordable rental housing complex, 375 for hotels on roads of 30 ft width, and 400 for government offices, and 500 for in-situ rehabilitation of slum clusters. Earlier, the FAR for group housing was around 50-200 (with 30% ground coverage which has now been increased to 40%). The FAR for hotels and government offices was 150, and 400 for in-situ rehabilitation.

FAR is the ratio of a building's total combined floor area across all floors to the total area of the plot it sits on. It effectively caps the height of a building based on the plot size.

The plan's development-control norms removed height restrictions on many categories of buildings subject to statutory clearances.

This included areas within in-situ rehabilitation, godown plots, group housing complex, studio apartment, state bhaban/states guest house, hotel, shopping centres, informal bazaars, wholesale markets, hotels, service apartment, industrial plots, townships, amusement park, sports centres, golf courses, government offices, healthcare centres, and premises for education, police and fire offices and socio-cultural facilities, among others.

Others remained for areas with environmental, heritage, security and other statutory considerations. Lutyens' Bungalow Zone and Civil Lines bungalows, for instance, will continue to follow lines planned in central government guidelines.

Around 150 sq km along the border of the National Capital Territory will be exempt from this policy of densification and vertical growth, and here at least 50% green cover will be maintained.

Gupta said that the plan reduced complexities, and trimmed 133 categories of difficult-to-implement rules, such as co-working spaces, startup hubs and clock kitchens to prepare Delhi's economy for future needs. It is essential to create new jobs, and to promote entrepreneurship in a changing economy. Master Plan-2047 will provide an integrated framework for planning Delhi as a major centre for new technology, innovation and modern industries," the CM said.

The flexible FAR and height norms are expected to facilitate vertical redevelopment in areas where infrastructure can support greater intensity of development. In other parts, predominantly on horizontal expansion.

The plan also allowed commercial plots except activities in residential plots abutting streets and roads having width 30 metre right of way (ROW) and more, in all categories of colonies, which are neither notified as mixed use nor as commercial streets, shall be permitted on ground floor or first floor level, integrated into the plot, subject to payment of charges," the MPD said.

All types of commercial activities are permitted on such residential plots except activities involving any kind of obnoxious, hazardous, inflammable, non-compatible and polluting substances or process, only on the ground floor or first floor (in case of still), it said.

"This is the highest FAR being provided in the city along with various other incentives. We have already received much interest in TOD projects since we revised the norms in April," said Delhi Development Authority vice-chairman, N Saravana Kumar.

DISABLED MAN PUSHED TO DEATH FROM MUM LOKAL

MUMBAI: A 62-year-old physically challenged man died on Thursday after allegedly being pushed out of a moving local train in Mumbai after a fellow passenger following an argument, police said, adding that the accused has been arrested.

The victim, identified as Kejriwal Dinesh, was allegedly pushed off the train by 48-year-old Amjad Saifuddin Shaikh following an argument over sitting near a coach dedicated for physically disabled passengers, MP police said.

A case has been registered under Sections 281 (rash driving), 286A (wrongful restraint) and 106(1) (causing death by negligence) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, they said.

The injured were identified as Deepak, Aijaz, Deepak, Sahzad, Bhagurath and Mukesh Kumar, police said.

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{ OUR TAKE }

A bolder India on China border

Tranquillity on the LAC alone will ensure the full normalisation of the bilateral relationship

Days after the external affairs ministry tacitly acknowledged a face-off between Indian and Chinese forces in the Arunachal Pradesh sector this month, Union minister Kiren Rijiju has spoken about confusion arising from differing perceptions of the boundary and increased Chinese military activity on high ridges along the frontier. Rijiju also dismissed reports that Chinese troops had intruded into Indian territory. An opposition party and a civil society group in Arunachal Pradesh had claimed that Chinese troops were expanding their presence in the area and denying Indian troops access to the Shera 5 patrolling point. China and India continue to disagree on the next steps to normalise the situation along the Line of Actual Control (LAC). Withdrawal of troops to peace-time positions is yet to happen despite the two countries reaching an understanding on disengagement in October 2024. Even an agreement between the Special Representatives on the border issue in August 2025 on creating an expert group under the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC) has been unsuccessful in exploring an "early harvest in boundary delimitation". New Delhi has unequivocally asserted that the state of border affairs has ramifications for the overall India-China relationship, and the two sides should avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation.

Rijiju mentioned that China has "cast an eye" on certain areas because of the lack of border demarcation, and that locals are concerned due to increased Chinese military activity on the high ridges. This specifically challenges China's repeated assertions of desiring better relations with India that lead to a win-win situation for both countries. India is correct in maintaining that peace and tranquillity on the LAC alone will ensure the full normalisation of the bilateral relationship, despite Beijing's calls to put the border issue in its "appropriate place". China's use of gray zone and salami slicing tactics in other territorial disputes is well documented. The focus in ongoing efforts to normalise bilateral relations must now turn to the border issue so that both sides can advance the demarcation exercise in good faith wherever feasible. An unsettled boundary will always leave India at a disadvantage, widen the trust deficit between the two countries, and allow China an edge in setting the terms of engagement.

What Gor did not say in Kashmir

India and Pakistan are at it again — and the immediate cause remains a country in the West. Coinciding with US Ambassador Sergio Gor's visit to Jammu and Kashmir where he made a statement that many see as affirming India's territorial integrity, a separate spate of tit-for-tat diplomacy has been playing out between the neighbours. In Islamabad's removal of parking poles from the Indian High Commission and New Delhi's reciprocal act of removing the queueing lines outside the Pakistani High Commission, what is being ignored is the import of Gor's statement *per se*.

To begin with, rather than calling J&K an integral part of India, the US ambassador chose to designate the region as "an important part". This taxonomical distinction ought to be sobering for both sides. Gor has merely continued the US habit of keeping the neighbours vying for the White House's unambiguous support on their respective positions on the Kashmir issue. In choosing to visit the Union Territory and making encouraging statements about tourism at a time when New Delhi is less than pleased about Islamabad's strengthening rapport in Washington DC, Gor may be making an attempt to assuage India's concerns. Additionally, an obfuscation of tensions surrounding the ongoing trade issues and sanctions between India and the US may also be on the agenda. Predictably, Pakistan lodged a "strong demarche" over what it calls the "factually incorrect" statement of Gor. While Pakistan's reaction may bolster the weight of Gor's words, it's important to see them for what they actually achieve. In policy terms, almost nothing changes. Even the faith in the signalled India-US bonhomie may turn out to be short-lived, given the unpredictability of US foreign policy in general and Donald Trump in particular.

Trump may escape the consequences of his mess

The US president's obsessions may have exacted serious costs and turned off sections of the electorate, but two factors may shield his party in the mid-term elections

From multiple mainstream news sources, a disturbing picture has emerged of how President Donald Trump spends his time. He remains fixated on a narrow set of concerns quickly building monuments to his own "greatness", such as giant arch to reshape the skyline of Washington, DC; clamping down on immigration and pursuing his vain quest to end birthright citizenship; pressuring congressional Republicans to pass the SAVE act designed to make it harder for American citizens to vote; securing a more restrictive nuclear deal with Iran than the one achieved by Barack Obama; and his own sagging popularity, which he insists is vastly undervalued by public opinion polls.

In the past, a president who showed so little concern for the welfare of the American people would pay a steep price in the mid-term elections. But Trump may escape this reckoning because of the political conditions that now define the electoral landscape.

Let's start with his obsessions. One striking fact is that most have nothing to do with the issues that concern the broad public. High prices remain a worry for most Americans, even though the rate of inflation has slowed in the years since the Covid pandemic. Trump has made things worse with his

war on Iran. Gas prices have surged, but he has dismissed popular complaints and shows little empathy for those struggling to manage. For years, polls have shown that Americans trust Republicans to better manage the economy (an eddy in itself, because the data show generally better economic performance under the Democrats), but Trump has dissipated this partisan advantage.

Tariffs were intended to be the cornerstone of his second-term economic project. They were to accomplish multiple goals — revive American industry by increasing the cost of imports, especially from China and low-wage countries; yield a surge in federal revenues that would allow tax cuts without increasing the deficit; and hold down prices because the cost would be paid by foreign manufacturers without being passed along to American consumers. Most economists scoffed at this agenda, questioning how its various goals could be reconciled in practice. Then, Trump imposed tariffs as a foreign policy tool, raising and lowering rates according to his whims to compel other nations to accede to American demands.

As a result of the consistent application of tariffs, it is difficult to say whether they might have achieved any of his economic goals. Certainly there has been no significant industrial resurgence during his second term. Manufacturing jobs have barely increased. Despite pleas from fellow Republicans to focus on the economy, Trump shows little interest.

At the outset of Trump's second term, he enjoyed widespread public support for an immigration crackdown. His predecessor, Joe Biden, had

been slow to recognise that lax border controls troubled a majority of Americans, even if they were sympathetic to the plight of immigrants who had entered the country and lived here as law-abiding, taxpaying residents for years.

The second term crackdown, directed by Trump's trusted aide Stephen Miller, soon became a political liability, however. Excessive force and violence by federal Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) agents turned opinion against the administration's heavy-handed methods, much as they did in Trump's first term.

Although the president's loyal supporters in the Make America Great Again (MAGA) ranks continue to stand by his restrictive immigration policies, those who gave it their conditional blessing have been alienated by its implementation.

Trump also took aim at the longstanding legal status of birthright citizenship. He hoped that a conservative US Supreme Court would adopt the administration's assertion that the Fourteenth Amendment did not extend to those who had entered the country illegally. The Court ruled against him. But even that outcome has not put an end to his obsession.

Ever since he lost the 2020 presidential election, Donald Trump has insisted he was cheated out of victory by fraud, with many ballots cast by ineligible voters. Election denialism has become a central MAGA tenet. The president has thrown his support behind the SAVE legislation, which would require prospective voters to provide official documentation of their citizenship status. In fact, numerous



In the past, a president who showed so little concern for the welfare of the American people would pay a price in the mid-term elections. SUTTERSTOCK

studies have demonstrated that voter fraud is exceedingly rare in the US. The measure would disenfranchise millions of voters who lack the required documentation.

Republicans in the US Senate have refused to put the bill up for a vote, knowing it cannot meet the 60-vote threshold needed to overcome a filibuster. None of this has deterred Trump, however, as he has urged them to end the filibuster and vetoed or threatened to veto other legislation until the Senate approves the SAVE Act.

Finally, he has ensured himself in a contest with Iran from which he has no clear exit. In February 2025, he joined Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in a reckless attempt to overthrow the entrenched Iranian revolutionary regime by attacking its leadership, while also targeting the Iranian nuclear programme that the US and Israel had claimed to eliminate the previous year. Trump's war goals have shifted over the course of the conflict (regime change has disappeared from the list, while he now has to resolve access to the Strait of Hormuz since the Iranians have effectively gained control). But the president is most insistent that the US achieve tighter restrictions on the Iranian nuclear programme than the deal Obama negotiated in 2015, from which Trump withdrew during his first term. The picture for Donald Trump and the Republicans appears bleak. Why,

then, might they escape a political backlash in the upcoming mid-term elections? Two factors stand out.

First, Republicans have shielded themselves from electoral repercussions by redrawing congressional districts in states they control. Today, there are many fewer competitive seats in the House of Representatives than two decades ago. While it remains likely that the Democrats will reclaim the House, Republican losses will be limited and thus leave Democrats with a slim majority. Add to this the difficulty that Democrats face as they seek control of the Senate, where the bulk of seats contested this fall are in reliably Republican states.

Second, the Democrats have not agreed on a programme or message to take advantage of Trump's weaknesses. Unhappy though voters are with the Republican brand, they continue to express low approval of the Democratic Party. Most of the energy in its ranks is in its progressive wing.

But whether the party's leftist candidates can win in key battleground states and House districts remains very much in question. If they cannot prevail, President Trump will escape the consequences of his peculiar obsessions.

Andrew J Polsky is professor emeritus, Department of Political Science, Hunter College, CUNY. The views expressed are personal

All of us should have the right to age with dignity

This August, the first children of free India turn 79. lakhs more are older than India's independence itself. Lakshmi, born in the monsoon of 1947, has lived the entire arc of independent India, from ration cards to UPI. She now inhabits a country transformed in every respect but one: Its laws still assume that a woman will catch her when she falls. The household, in much of India, no longer exists in the form the law imagines.

The Sample Registration System's latest report puts India's total fertility rate at 1.3, i.e., below replacement levels. India has roughly 150 million people over 60 years of age; by 2050, that number will touch 347 million. And the transition is geographically uneven. The states that led India's fertility decline are ageing first: in Kerala and Tamil Nadu, the 18-29 cohort is barely 17% of the population; in Karnataka, just over 19%. The question is who now stands in the middle.

As economist Amarendra Nandy recently wrote, India's welfare State has long been hidden inside the household — the joint family, co-resident children, and unpaid female care quietly caring for the elderly. That arrangement is dissolving under urbanisation, migration, and women's rightful entry into paid work. Its costs have not disappeared; they are just being borne by the next generation. Lakshmi's daughter, at 48, manages a career, a teenager's board examinations, and her mother's medication chart. The "sandwich generation" is trying to balance it all — and within it, long-term care falls disproportionately on "her". Every gap in the eldercare ecosystem that the State fails to close, is plugged — mostly unacknowledged — by the time and earnings of India's working-age women.

What does the State provide? More than we realise, and much less than what is needed. There is now health insurance for every citizen over 70, a national helpline, tax concessions, and an old-age pension whose central contribution — ₹200 a month, for the poorest elderly between 60 and 79 — has not been revised since 2007. States top it up, unevenly, which means an elderly widow's monthly income depends on her PIN code.

The problem is not that schemes do not exist. It is that they are schemes: fixed at discretion, revised at will, fragmented across ministries, received as benevolence, and enforceable by no one.

And money is the narrowest of gaps. There is no regulated caregiving profession: Anyone may call themselves a caregiver, with no qualification, standard, or register to turn to.

answer to, and no binding quality framework governs the care homes or agencies to which more families must now turn. India has fewer than 500 practising geriatricians for its 150 million elderly. The Indian Academy of Geriatrics' own benchmark of one specialist per 6,000 older adults implies a need of over 27,000. Our public spaces are built for the young. And the newest predator is digital, with the elderly being the primary targets for fraudsters. Each of these gaps is absorbed, privately and invisibly, by families.

The courts have begun to say what the legislature has not. In July, the High Court of Karnataka, hearing the case of a 74-year-old woman suffering from gangrene and abandoned by her family, observed that the State should examine a comprehensive legislative framework for "senior citizens in need of care and protection", modelled on the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015. The court is saying the elderly need an Act that addresses the need for rescue, shelter, health care and protection — and that the only existing law for the elderly does not provide it. The Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007, is a mammoth piece of work for "senior citizens in need of care and protection", modelled on the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015. The court is saying the elderly need an Act that addresses the need for rescue, shelter, health care and protection — and that the only existing law for the elderly does not provide it. The Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007, is a mammoth piece of work for "senior citizens in need of care and protection", modelled on the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015. The court is saying the elderly need an Act that addresses the need for rescue, shelter, health care and protection — and that the only existing law for the elderly does not provide it.

forcement statute. It treats old age as a family dispute to be adjudicated, not as a stage of life to be lived with dignity. The Madhya Pradesh High Court recently took suo motu notice of a video showing elderly women assaulted at an unregistered Indore shelter home. No central law mandates the registration of such homes, and none recognises institutional elder abuse as a distinct offence.

The Supreme Court has read dignity into the heart of Article 21 — and dignity does not expire at 60. Article 41 of the Constitution directs the State to make effective provision for public assistance in old age. Parliament knows how to honour such a directive: it made a child's education an enforceable right in 2009, and food a legal entitlement in 2013. Aging with dignity is the promise that is still waiting its turn. The scaffolding exists. What is missing is the political and legislative will to say that dignity in old age cannot be a favour the State extends, or a scheme it announces, but a right that the citizen owns.

What would such a right contain? The Karnataka court's order outlines the floor: rescue, protection, shelter, health care and community-based care — owed as entitlements, not as discretionary favours. And a foster where an older citizen can claim it. A right for the mother is time returned to the daughter.

The generation that built the institutions the rest of us inherited is ageing differently from every generation before it — living longer, more urban, more alone. It has asked for relief, and its silence has been mistaken for an absence of need. What it needs now is a framework that secures agency and dependence, not one that adjudicates dependence. A scheme can be withdrawn; a right must be enforced.

It is often said that India will grow old before it grows rich. The real question is whether it can afford to grow old before it builds the guardrails for dignified ageing.

Barkha Deva works on policy on ageing and social legislation. The views expressed are personal

{ ABHIJEET DIPKE } CONVENOR, COCKROACH JANATA PARTY

When political leaders are not doing anything for students, why should people vote for them?... People should see in what conditions their children are studying. The dogs of these ministers get better facilities than this

IndiGo's transition plan has one risk too many

In April 2024, IndiGo generated a lot of buzz when it placed an order for 30 A350-900 — a twin-engine, long-range aircraft — to begin transitioning from a no-frills carrier to a network carrier. In October 2025, the airline added another 30 aircraft to its order. Deliveries, as per the latest update, are likely to begin in mid-2028.

When the airline first announced plans to become a network carrier, the market reacted with caution. As the deadline for the induction of the long-range aircraft draws nearer, experts and industry insiders remain sceptical about the plan. This piece will elaborate a few reasons behind the scepticism, some internal to IndiGo and some external and/or structural factors.

Let's start with the internal constraints. First, IndiGo, with its 430 aircraft in operation, over 500 ordered, and 68,000 employees, is already a large operation that is required to deliver consistently, every day of the year. Airline experts are believing keeping it going in present form is challenging enough, without adding new variables — IndiGo still has plenty of opportunity in its present niche and should not give in to "unrealistic ambitions" they maintain.

Moreover, airlines get built with a certain DNA and changing that mid-course doesn't always work out. Jet Airways was structured and operated as a full-service airline from its inception in 1993. As the environment around it changed, Jet tried to adapt, reinvent, and reboot in every manner possible, but to no avail. In the end, it had to shut shop. As one observer said in the time, selling Oberoi rooms at OYO rates simply wasn't viable in the long run.

But the bigger hurdles for IndiGo's plans are likely structural or external. Even if it were to surmount internal challenges and smoothly transition from a no-frills airline to a full-service one, there are at least three or four factors out-

side its control. One's the existing competition. In one direction, there's Lufthansa, British Airways, Air France, Emirates, Etihad and Qatar Airways to just with, and in the other, there's Singapore Airlines, JAL, Korean Air and a clutch of other Thai and Malaysian carriers. Several have been in the business for the last 50-70 years. None of them are going to compete any traffic. If the competition can make life difficult, it will.

Even if fear of competition will not deter a resolute new entrant, experts point out that Indian airports are not geared to facilitate the kind of hub-and-spoke operations that network carriers are structured around. Many of the metro airports, for instance, require flyers to arrive at one terminal and then make their way — often by road, via connections outside the airport premises — to another terminal to board an international flight, which in all likelihood will take you to your last destination if it is Buenos Aires or Botswana, for instance.

Compare this with what Emirates — which picks up flyers from nine different Indian cities — has to do to diversify destinations — offers. Pick-up from the nine cities, arrival at Dubai, and within a 1.5-2-hour window that one can spend shopping and eating in the transit zones, boarding for one's end-destination.

Moving into long haul also makes the airline lose some of its current cost advantage since the costs of operating an A350 doesn't vary dramatically between operators — while the unique geography and spread of metropolitan and Tier 2 and 3 cities in India allows IndiGo to use its A320s aggressively through the day. This lets it beat the competition by better utilising an expensive asset while reducing ground handling and other costs since the same staff handle multiple flights in a day.

While the industry gives the planned foray the benefit of doubt — well earned, with admiration for its current operations (glitches notwithstanding) — wishes IndiGo luck, the risks continue to weigh on the minds of the aviation sector watchers.

Anjali Bhargava writes on governance, infrastructure, and the social sector. The views expressed are personal



A Russian missile strike in Kyiv on Thursday.

Russian strikes kill at least 16 in Kyiv region

KYIV: Russia pounded the Ukrainian capital Kyiv and the surrounding region with scores of missiles and drones in a nighttime aerial attack that lasted for hours and killed at least 16 people, officials said on Thursday. Russia's overnight barrage also included cruise missiles and fast-flying jet-powered drones that put further strain on air defences, the Ukrainian air force said.

'North Korea may have up to 120 nuclear weapons' SEUL: North Korea may possess as many as 120 nuclear weapons, South Korea's defence minister Ahn Gyu-back said, more than twice the 57 warheads cited by US President Donald Trump, who is seeking to revive diplomacy with its leader Kim Jong-un.

Germany: 14,000 heat-related deaths in summer FRANKFURT: Germany registered a record of around 14,000 heat-related deaths this summer as Europe struggled through a series of punishing heatwaves, official data showed on Thursday.

Trump: US waging economic warfare against Iran, its allies

Bloomberg

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON/TEHRAN: US President Donald Trump threatened Iran and its trading partners with economic isolation after months of military strikes and a maritime blockade failed to force Tehran to capitulate. Trump didn't specify what measures he would take or which countries would be targeted, but his threat put an immediate focus on China, which buys the bulk of Iran's oil. Brent crude prices advanced for a fifth day to about \$94 a barrel, reaching the highest this month.

China, Iran react

In its first reaction to Trump's comments, Beijing said sanctions and pressure wouldn't work and called for a diplomatic resolution. Iran, meanwhile, said Trump's threats were a "diversion" from America's own crises of unprecedented debt and surging interest costs.

"Doubling down on failed policies will only bring further defeat — and enmity of Iranians," Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi said on X. "US economic terrorism threatens global economy and sovereignty worldwide."

It's unclear what new economic punishment the US could impose, if any, that Tehran hasn't already endured. Targeting Iranian oil sales would also risk fresh confrontation with China, the buyer of almost all Iranian crude exports.

That would complicate Trump's bid to extend a tariff truce with President Xi Jinping, who is set to visit the US next month. "I don't think there's a magic bullet," said Daniel Fried, a former US ambassador to Poland, told Bloomberg TV. "Is there more leverage we could apply against the Iranian economy? Probably. But I think



US sailors work on the flight deck of USS George Washington as the aircraft carrier transits the Arabian Sea on Thursday. The George Washington Carrier Strike Group is operating in West Asia during a scheduled deployment after arriving in the CENTCOM theatre.

they've got the workarounds pretty much in place right now. Our leverage is not great in the short run."

Munitions shortages

Trump's comments signal how the US, beset by munitions shortages and rising costs, wants to pivot from a military campaign that's eliminated most of Iran's top leaders and battered its economy, but has so far failed to bring about its surrender.

China doesn't recognise unilateral sanctions, but its state entities generally stay away from blacklisted oil. Its biggest state banks also have a history of complying with US sanctions against Iran, North Korea and even top officials in Hong Kong, in order to avoid losing access to the US dollar-clearing system.

Washington has already sanctioned some independent Chinese teapot refineries and firms since the US launched the war against Iran in late Febru-

ary. But so far, the US has stopped short of targeting the major Chinese banks that finance the trade.

In May, China ordered domestic companies not to comply with US sanctions on five refineries, while its biggest banks were caught between Beijing's directive and the risk of losing access to the US financial system.

"Sanctions and pressure will not help resolve the issue," Chinese foreign ministry spokesman Lin Jian told reporters at in Beijing on Thursday. "China calls on relevant parties to take responsible measures and sought to solve the issue through diplomatic and political means."

Trump demanded that all countries stop giving Iran access to exchange houses, cash transfers, swap lines, ship registries, front companies and avenues to smuggle out its oil. He also sought to rally other nations that have so far declined

to support his war on the Islamic Republic, saying the US needs all its allies to help "isolate, and defeat, the Iran threat".

UAE boost

The US got a boost on Tuesday, when the United Arab Emirates severed economic ties with Iran after accusing it of firing two ballistic missiles at its territorial waters. Iran denied responsibility for the attack.

The UAE ranked as Iran's top trade partner last year, with Tehran relying on the relationship for access to foreign goods and hard currency, followed by China, Turkey and India.

Trump's aim is to force Iran into fresh negotiations meant to end the war for good, force Tehran to abandon its nuclear program and release its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz.

Those goals were spelled out in a memorandum of understanding the two sides signed in June, but later collapsed amid a flurry of tit-for-tat strikes.

Ruling party veteran elected as Bangladesh's new president

Reuters

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DHAKA: Bangladesh lawmakers elected veteran Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) leader Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir as the country's new president on Thursday, making the long-time opposition figure the head of state after his party came to power in a major political transition.

The BNP returned to power in February in the long wake of the fall of Sheikh Hasina's Awami League government in 2024. While the presidency is largely ceremonial, Alamgir will serve as head of state and commander-in-chief of the armed forces. Executive authority remains with the prime minister and cabinet in the South Asian nation of about 173 million people.

Alamgir, 78, defeated Oli



Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir

Ahmed, a retired army colonel and chairman of the Liberal Democratic Party and candidate of the Jamaat-e-Islami-led 11-party opposition alliance, in a parliamentary vote.

Chief Election Commissioner A.M.M. Nasir Uddin declared Alamgir the winner after the 255-to-88 vote.

The BNP and its allies hold a two-thirds majority in parlia-

ment after winning the February 12 general election, which returned the party to power after years in opposition and brought Tarique Rahman to the office of prime minister.

The resignation last month of Mohammed Shahabuddin on health grounds before the end of his five-year term triggered the presidential election. A former Awami League politician and close confidant of Hasina, Shahabuddin was elected president in 2023 when her party was at the height of its power.

Hasina has been living in India since fleeing Bangladesh after a mass uprising ousted her government in August 2024 and has said that she intends to return in December this year.

One of the BNP's longest-serving leaders, Alamgir served as the party's secretary-general from 2016 until his nomination for the presidency.

2 Khalistan supporters warned by Canada police about threat to their lives

Anirudh Bhattacharyya

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TORONTO: Two pro-Khalistan separatists in Canada have received letters from Canada police warning them of a potential threat to their lives.

While the secessionist group Sikhs for Justice (SFJ) has blamed India for being the source of the threat, the letters, or duty to warn notices, pointed to a possible criminal angle.

Citing the letters from the Royal Canadian Mounted Police (RCMP), the agency Canadian Press said they stated, "You may be putting yourself at risk if you spend time in any residence, vehicle or location frequented by those who engage in a criminal lifestyle."

According to the news outlet Globe and Mail, the recipients

of the letters include SFJ's coordinator in Canada for the so-called Khalistan Referendum Inderjeet Singh Gosal from Calcutta in Ontario and Manjinder Singh from Abbotsford in British Columbia. In interviews with Canadian media, Gosal linked the threat to the next phase of the "referendum" to be held in Edmonton, capital of the province of Alberta, on October 18.

Gosal replaced Hardeep Singh Nijjar as SFJ's Canadian coordinator after the latter was killed in Surrey, British Columbia, on June 18, 2023. That murder led to the cratering of relations between India and Canada after then PM Justin Trudeau stated in the House of Commons three months later that there were "credible allegations" of a potential link between Indian agents and the killing.

NASA MISSION TO RESCUE SATELLITE ENDS IN FAILURE

WASHINGTON: A complicated mission to save a Nasa satellite from burning up in the atmosphere has failed, the US space agency said on Wednesday, as the rescue spacecraft could not be controlled. The Swift space telescope, which studies the most powerful explosions in the universe, will now likely plunge back to earth and disintegrate along the way later this year.

The \$30 million dollar mission attempted to send a robot to grab the telescope and move it farther into orbit. "This is not the outcome we were working towards, but it does not change why this mission was worth attempting," Nasa administrator Jared Isaacman said.

"The team moved with extraordinary speed to give Swift a chance to carry out more science while advancing capabilities America will need for satellite servicing in the future," Isaacman added.

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CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



READ EVERY SUNDAY

The veteran and his understudy

KL Rahul and Devdutt Padikkal already look like a partnership India could nurture

Somshuva Laha
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KOLKATA: No one watching the Galle Test missed that big, warm hug KL Rahul gave Devdutt Padikkal out of relief after the review that he almost didn't take went his way. Nor did anyone following that broadcast closely miss that peck Rahul almost planted on his cheek. It spoke of gratitude, but also of the affection that grows among players who are on the road year-round.

For Rahul and Padikkal, it's a bond that goes deeper because they turn out for Karnataka as well, churning runs while putting on massive partnerships together. So maybe it's not bad after all that Padikkal is batting at No 3, leading India a top-order stability that they don't have to work on for a change.

Rahul and Padikkal put on 150 for the second wicket in the first innings, then another 65 in the second. Padikkal made 167, the defining innings of India's 165-run victory. Rahul made 82 and 35. Across their two partnerships they contributed 227 runs. But the numbers do not quite explain why it looked so natural.

Rahul is 34, a veteran of 69 Tests, and has spent years learning the peculiar demands of international batting while not being assured of a particular position for a long time. Padikkal, 26, is still an understudy. Yet he didn't look overawed by the senior partner. Nor did Rahul appear to be managing him. They simply seemed to know what the other was doing.

The way Rahul was almost goaded into taking that review reflected that chemistry. Rahul had been given out low in India's second innings in Galle and was already walking away.

But Padikkal, at the non-striker's end, wasn't contented. He told Rahul that the ball might have been high. Rahul, reluctantly, went upstairs. Replays showed the ball was missing the stumps.

The embrace that followed was

a small celebration of something India rarely gets to manufacture — a batting partnership whose understanding exists before the players arrive at the crease.

Padikkal was confident enough to challenge Rahul, and he trusted him enough to listen. That isn't just friendship, that's trust. "I felt like it was out," Rahul said afterwards.

"The only doubt that I had was, did I get outside the line?" Padikkal's response was simple but practical. "When you get chances like that a batter, it's a gift, it's a second chance," Rahul said.

Beyond the winnings of this Galle Test, India may have stumbled upon something more valuable than a hundred from a No 3. This could be the beginning of a relationship at the top of the order, based on a familiarity built in Karnataka, through domestic cricket, India A and, increasingly, at the top level. There is something particularly useful about that history when the two are batting together.

"He understands the way I bat, the tempo in which I bat, and I do the same as well," Padikkal said. "When you have that kind of chemistry, I think it helps in stitching that partnership and really pushing the limits of how far we can go."

That last part matters since partnerships are essentially about knowing how far the other player can be pushed.

Rahul's natural game, particularly in Test cricket, is built around time. Padikkal brings a different tempo. His 167 in Galle was not a frenetic counterattack but an innings of calculated pressure, particularly against spin. He could afford the quiet over before suddenly finding a boundary. Rahul could then settle into the rhythm alongside him. The result was complementary rather than competitive.

There were other benefits as well. Rahul's presence appeared to give Padikkal the security to play his own game. He had been waiting for this opportunity, having last played a Test in 2024 and returning only because Sai Sudharsan was ruled out. He didn't arrive in Galle as an established No 3. He left with the strongest possible argument that he should remain there.

Rahul understood the significance. He called Padikkal's

He (Rahul) understands the way I bat, the tempo in which I bat, and I do the same as well. When you have that kind of chemistry, it helps in stitching that partnership and really pushing the limits of how far we can go.

DEVDUUTT PADIKKAL, on his partnership with KL Rahul



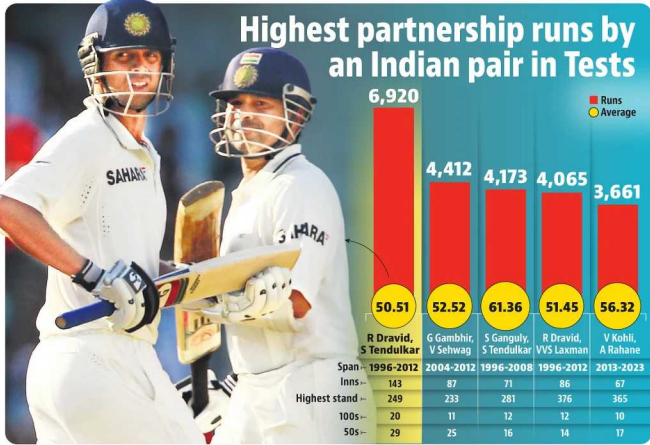
India's Devdutt Padikkal (L) and KL Rahul during Day 1 of the 1st Test against Sri Lanka at the Galle International Stadium.

innings "the defining part" of the Test, praising both the tempo and the ability to turn a start into a substantial score.

"Hopefully he carries this confidence into the next game and into his Test career as well," Rahul said. There is, therefore, a temptation to describe this as a small but crucial subplot in India's Test transition: the experienced player shepherding the youngster, getting a hundred and significant partnerships along the way.

There could be more to this. If Rahul remains at No 2 and Padikkal at No 3, the distinction between veteran and understudy could become an advantage rather than a hierarchy for India. As the emotional anchor, Rahul provides the knowledge to play out different conditions. Padikkal provides the freedom of someone whose international career is still in the early stages. And, crucially, they communicate all the time.

The best partnerships in Test cricket are often built on precisely that invisible currency. Sometimes it produces a valuable partnership, sometimes it simply stops a batsman from walking back to the pavilion. Either way, the team benefits.



Maresca, City and the shadow of Guardiola

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MUMBAI: The Etihad Stadium has had some work done over the off-season. The North Stand in particular received much attention. An additional 7,000 seats were fitted in. And once the work was complete, the section was rebranded the 'Pep Guardiola Stand'. Some proposed changes are still in progress, including a statue of Guardiola.

These are the tributes the club bestowed upon its greatest manager, who quit at the end of last season after 10 years at the helm. Under the 55-year-old Spaniard, City won six Premier League titles, three FA Cups, five League Cups, three Community Shields, the Champions League in 2023-24 and the UEFA Super Cup in 2023 and the UEFA Club Cup in 2023.

It is into the shadow of such a prominent figure at City, and in world football, that 46-year-old Enzo Maresca steps as the club's new manager. "It's fantastic, nice and exciting, and for me, a privilege," Maresca said, as quoted by The Guardian.

More than anything though, this will be a challenge at a club whose bar for success has been pushed to great heights. This is especially true given that City are going through a phase of transition.

A number of key players have moved on, starting with star-midfielder Rodri, who captain Spain to the World Cup title last month. Rodri's performance in the US earned him the Golden Ball and may put him in with a good chance of winning his second Ballon d'Or departure to Barcelona will leave a void in the midfield. Then there are the departures of John Stones, Nathan Ake, Manuel Akanji and Bernardo Silva.

So far, City have managed to secure the services of Nottingham Forest's Elliott Anderson, who came in for a club-record £106 million. That's a big price tag for a 23-year-old who will be expected

Premier League's appeal



to fill Rodri's role. Anderson did show he is capable of putting in those performances after impressing with England during the World Cup.

The club's radar is Argentina's wustaway Enzo Fernandez from Chelsea, but there is a chance that City will need to break the bank once again. The West London club has reportedly set an asking price of £120 million for the midfielder, if he is to reunite with Maresca.

The City midfield has also been bolstered by the arrival of Ayoub Bouadif, an 18-year-old Moroccan who dictated play for his team

against Brazil at the World Cup. This is not to say that City does not already have strong players in the ranks. Ryan Cherki is there, as is the flair of Omar Marmoush. And with Maresca — a manager who likes his wingers to run wide and deep — Jeremy Doku and Antoine Semenyo would relish the opportunity.

One who may benefit the most from that wing-play is a certain Erling Haaland. Having ended last season as City's premier striker, he returns for the new season as a cult hero. His exploits at the World Cup with Norway, which saw him



Man City's Erling Haaland (L) vies with Arsenal's Gabriel Magalhães during the Community Shield match in Cardiff on August 16.

score seven goals and take his team to the quarter-final, earned him favour among fans. I also saw Haaland turn into an internet sensation and a meme favourite.

The direct approach City might employ under Maresca seems to be tailor-made for Haaland. There will also be some expectations from Phil Foden. Once a star midfielder under Guardiola, he has been a shadow of himself in the past few seasons. But as Maresca looks to rebuild the midfield, Foden might be keen to make his mark for the new manager.

Maresca taking over from

Guardiola has a certain symmetry to it. After all, Maresca was Guardiola's assistant during the treble-winning campaign of 2023-24. Maresca also guided City's U-23 to the Premier League's developmental league title in 2020-21, before helping Leicester City win the EFL Championship in 2023-24.

At Chelsea, he helped the London club win the Conference League in 2024-25, followed by the Club World Cup in 2025. His first assignment for City however, did not go according to plan, as the team was beaten 3-0 by Arsenal at the end of an under-

whelming performance in the Community Shield last week.

Not much should be read from that one-off match however, as the new Premier League season ushers in a new period of English football.

This will be the first time since the 1985-86 season in which England's top-tier of football does not have a team managed by Sir Alex Ferguson, Arsene Wenger, Jose Mourinho, Jurgen Klopp and Guardiola — winners of 26 of the Premier League's 34 seasons.

Could Maresca etch his own name to Premier League history?

Refs boss Webb wants monitoring of set-piece fights

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LONDON: Premier League clubs have been warned to expect a tougher stance from officials on grappling and holding at set-pieces in the new season.

Howard Webb, English football's chief refereeing officer, believes there were too many instances last season of defenders dragging attackers to the ground that went unpunished during corners and free-kicks.

Arsenal won the Premier League title in part due to their expertise at set-pieces, with all managers and fans complaining about the Gunners' habit of wrestling opponents prior to the ball being delivered.

Webb is keen for referees and VAR officials to be more vigilant over the issue, starting with Arsenal's clash against Coventry at the Emirates Stadium in the opening fixture of the season on Friday. "I think fans can expect less warnings from referees (before fouls are given) than they might have seen previously, and I know (those warnings were) a source of frustration," he said on Wednesday.

"Fans can expect to see more situations being penalised, but not only in August or September, throughout the season."

A change for the coming season is the ability for VAR to check for attacking fouls at set-pieces and order them to be retaken, where a goal, penalty award or disciplinary sanction follows afterwards.

But Webb, a former Premier League and FIFA referee, doesn't want the flow of the game ruined by endless stoppages for fouls at set-pieces. "I'm not going to commit to say we're going to go from here to penalising lots of contact. Contact's still part of the game," he said.

Fans can expect less warnings from refs than they might have seen previously, and I know (those warnings were) a source of frustration

HOWARD WEBB, chief ref

said. "We still maintain a high threshold, but I would imagine we'll be at here this time next year and we'll be able to reflect on a season where more offences have been penalised."

Webb is also concerned by the aftermath of FIFA's decision to overturn the United States forward Folarin Balogun's ban for a red card during the World Cup. Webb fears there is growing belief in refereeing conspiracies among supporters following the Balogun controversy, which included US president Donald Trump admitting he told FIFA president Gianni Infantino to review the incident. "I was really troubled by it," Webb said. "We know that there was pressure placed by a politician on to FIFA, because that was admitted."

"And we know that the suspension was taken away for that particular tournament and suspended during a process which seemingly didn't exist before the tournament was started." Decisions were previously viewed as correct or incorrect, based on your judgement. Far too often now decisions are viewed as correct or corrupt by people who want to type all over social media."

NEERAJ-PATHIRAGE BATTLE YET AGAIN IN LAUSANNE DIAMOND LEAGUE

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LAUSANNE: The budding rivalry between rising Sri Lankan star Ramesh Pathirage and Indian ace Neeraj Chopra will once again hit the headlines when the two square off in the Lausanne Diamond League on Friday with a spot in the DL grand finale in Brussels at stake.

The duo will be up against each other three weeks after Pathirage clinched the gold and Chopra finished with a silver in the Glasgow Commonwealth Games.

The 23-year-old Pathirage has been in the form of his life this season, having also won the Doha and Rome Diamond League meetings, besides clinching gold in Glasgow with a throw of 89.75m. He also breached the coveted 90m mark with a season-leading throw of 92.62m in Rome in June. In fact, the Sri Lankan has won eight of the nine competitions he has participated so far in the season.

Chopra, on the other hand, is on a comeback trail after recovering from a lower back injury that has troubled him since September last year. The injury delayed his return until the Diamond League in Doha. He was not 100 per cent fit in Glasgow but was able to win a silver with a season's best throw of 85.80m.

"I can't say my fitness is there like before. But I'm getting there," the 28-year-old Chopra had said at the CWG.

After the CWG, Chopra has gone back to his base in Biel, Switzerland, where he is continuing his rehabilitation — training with childhood coach Jaiver Chaudhary and physio Ishan Marwah. One of the most consistent javelin throwers over two-time Olympic medalist Chopra has finished outside the top-two in just two competitions in the last five years.

AFI selection committee chairman Adile Sumariwalla has warned against writing off Chopra, saying the superstar Indian should not be scrutinised too harshly for winning a silver at times.



Neeraj Chopra.